



CITY: Pg 3

Kamla Nagar gets L-G attention



BUSINESS: Pg 10

PM says India strengthening its role as 'reliable' semiconductor supplier



FILM: Pg 12

Arjun celebrates responses to 'Dhurandhar 2'

IRAN SAYS IT WILL ATTACK US TECH FIRMS

Trump voices frustration with allies as Iran war, strait closure push fuel prices higher

ASSOCIATED PRESS

DUBAI: President Donald Trump expressed frustration Tuesday with allies who have been unwilling to do more to support the US war effort, telling them to "go get your own oil" as the conflict with Iran and its closure of the Strait of Hormuz sent average US gas prices past USD 4 a gallon.

The social media post came after US strikes hit a city that is home to one of Iran's main nuclear sites, sending a massive fireball into the sky, and Tehran attacked a fully loaded Kuwaiti oil tanker in the Persian Gulf.

The attacks showed the intensity of the war more than a month after the US and Israel launched it. The conflict has left more than 3,000 dead and caused major disruptions to the world's supply of oil and natural gas, roiling global markets.

Meanwhile, Iran's Revolutionary Guards have threatened to target major US technology



Bystanders look at rising smoke as an Israeli strike hits a building near the airport road in Beirut, Lebanon, on Tuesday

AP/PTI

KEY POINTS

- » Trump tells allies "go get your own oil" amid Iran war tensions
- » US strikes hit Iranian city housing key nuclear facilities
- » Iran attacks Kuwaiti oil tanker near Dubai; blaze later contained
- » Conflict death toll crosses 3,000 across multiple regions
- » Iran's Strait of Hormuz control disrupts global oil and gas supply
- » Trump blames UK, France for refusing to join war effort

FRANCE, SPAIN, ITALY RESTRICT US MILITARY ACCESS TO BASES AND AIRSPACE

The central city is home to one of three nuclear enrichment sites attacked by the US during a previous war last June, and analysts believe much of Iran's highly enriched uranium is likely stored there.

Iran's stranglehold on the Strait of Hormuz, the waterway leading out of the Persian Gulf through which a fifth of the world's oil is transported during peacetime, has driven up global oil prices, as have Tehran's attacks on regional energy infrastructure. That has shaken stock markets around the world and pushed up the cost of many basic goods.

Spot prices of Brent crude, the international standard, hovered around USD 107 a barrel Tuesday, up more than 45 per cent since the war started Feb. 28.

Trump directed blame at US allies like the United Kingdom and France, which have refused to enter a war with no clear endgame **Continued on P4**

Reshuffle: Chanchal Kumar appointed I&B Secretary

Sanjay Lohiya to be Financial Services Secy

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: In a major bureaucratic reshuffle, the Centre on Tuesday appointed senior IAS officer Chanchal Kumar as Secretary in the Ministry of Information and Broadcasting, according to an official order issued by the Personnel Ministry.

Kumar, a 1992 batch Indian Administrative Service officer of the Bihar cadre, is currently serving as Secretary in the Ministry of Development of North Eastern Region. He will replace Sanjay Jaju, who has been appointed as the new Secretary of the DoNER Ministry.

The Appointments Committee of the Cabinet

approved the changes as part of a wider reorganisation across key ministries. Among other appointments, Sanjay Lohiya, presently Additional Secretary in the Ministry of Mines, has been named Special Secretary in the Department of Financial Services under the Finance Ministry. He is slated to assume charge as Secretary of the department after the retirement of incumbent Nagaraju Maddirala on May 31.

Abhishek Singh, a 1995 batch IAS officer of the Nagaland cadre and currently Director General of the National Informatics Centre, has been appointed Director General of the National Testing Agency **Continued on P4**

Stampede at Nalanda temple kills eight

SHO suspended; probe ordered with CCTV review and forensic support

MPOST BUREAU

BIHAR SHARIF (BIHAR): At least eight devotees, most of them women, lost their lives and eight others were injured in a stampede at a temple in Bihar's Nalanda district on Tuesday morning, officials confirmed.

The incident occurred at the Sheelta Mata temple in Bihar Sharif, which falls under the Deep Nagar police station limits, amid a large gathering of worshippers. Authorities said the rush of devotees during the morning hours is believed to have triggered the chaos.

Bihar Sharif Assistant Superintendent of Police Noorul Haque said, "At least eight devotees, mostly women, died in the stampede at Shi-



Family members of victims mourn outside a hospital after a stampede at the Sheelta Mata temple killed at least eight devotees and injured eight, in Bihar Sharif, Nalanda district, on Tuesday

PTI

tala Mata temple on Tuesday morning. Eight devotees were also injured in the incident. Police personnel and officials

of the district administration have reached the spot, and the rescue work is on.

Emergency teams were

KEY POINTS

- » Incident occurred Tuesday morning amid heavy rush of worshippers
- » Authorities working to identify victims; cause of stampede under investigation
- » Prime Minister Narendra Modi announces Rs 2 lakh ex gratia for deceased, Rs 50,000 for injured
- » Bihar CM Nitish Kumar announces Rs 6 lakh compensation for victims' families

deployed soon after the incident, with police and district officials overseeing rescue operations and **Continued on P4**

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New I-T law, higher securities transaction tax on F&O kicks in

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: A sweeping set of tax reforms and financial changes will come into force from April 1, marking the start of the 2026-27 fiscal year, with implications for taxpayers, investors, and businesses across sectors.

At the centre of the transition is the introduction of the Income-tax Act, 2025, which will replace the six-decade-old Income-tax Act, 1961. The new law seeks to reorganise existing provisions into a more structured and accessible format while retaining the underlying tax policy. Officials said the move is aimed at simplifying compliance

WHAT CHANGES

- » New Income Tax Act, 2025 replaces the old law
- » Simpler format and single "tax year" system
- » Late ITR filing still allows TDS refunds (no penalty)

HIGHER TAX ON F&O TRADING (STT)

- » Futures: 0.02% to 0.05%
- » Options: up to 0.15%
- » Aimed at reducing speculative trading

without altering the fundamental tax framework.

To ensure a smooth shift, the Income Tax Department has stated that its e-filing portal will support both the old and new

systems during the transition period. Proceedings related to earlier years, including assessments and appeals, will continue under the previous law until they are fully resolved. Taxpayers fil-

LOWER TCS ON FOREIGN SPENDING

- » Overseas tour packages: 20% to 2%
- » Education/medical remittances: 5% to 2%
- » 20-year tax holiday for data centre services

IT SECTOR RELIEF

- » Safe harbour limit raised from Rs 300 crore to Rs 2,000 crore
- » Less tax disputes



starting June, will be governed by the new legislation. One of the key structural changes is the introduction of a unified "tax year" concept, replacing the distinction between assessment year and previous year. The law also allows taxpayers to claim refunds for tax deducted at source even if income tax returns are filed after the deadline, without attracting penalties. Alongside these structural reforms, several Budget announcements will take effect simultaneously. Among them is an increase in the Securities Transaction Tax on equity derivatives trading. The tax on futures contracts will rise from 0.02 per cent to 0.05 **Continued on P4**

ABOVE-NORMAL NIGHT TEMPERATURES LIKELY IN MOST REGIONS

IMD warns: Heatwave days set to rise

MPOST BUREAU

NEW DELHI: India is likely to experience a higher number of heatwave days across parts of the east, central and northwest regions, along with the southeastern peninsula, during the April to June period, the India Meteorological Department (IMD) said in its latest monthly outlook released on Tuesday.

Despite the warning on heatwaves, the IMD indicated that maximum temperatures across large parts of the country are expected to remain normal to below normal during the three-month period. Exceptions include much of east and northeast India, eastern parts of central



India, and adjoining peninsular areas, where above-normal maximum temperatures are forecast.

Minimum temperatures, however, are expected to remain above normal across most regions during the hot weather season. "During

the hot season (April-May-June), above-normal minimum temperatures are likely over most parts of the country except some regions of Maharashtra and Telangana, where normal to below normal minimum temperatures are likely," the IMD said.

For April specifically, the weather agency expects maximum temperatures to stay normal to below normal in many areas. Still, several regions including east and northeast India, parts of northwest India, and sections of southern peninsular India are

likely to record above-normal daytime temperatures. Minimum temperatures in April are also projected to remain above normal across most of the country, with only isolated pockets in the southern peninsula expected to see normal readings. **Continued on P4**

TAKEAWAYS

- » Minimum temperatures expected above normal across most regions during April to June
- » Maharashtra and Telangana may see normal to below-normal minimum temperatures
- » April maximum temperatures likely normal to below normal in many parts

- » East, northeast, northwest and southern peninsula may record above-normal April daytime temperatures
- » April minimum temperatures likely above normal across most of India
- » Some southern pockets may record normal minimum temperatures in April
- » Normal to above-normal rainfall forecast over most regions in April

DRAFT NORMS TIGHTEN SOCIAL MEDIA CONTROL

Centre may scrutinise online news content without any complaint

Move will bring YouTubers, X users under digital media ethics code

MPOST BUREAU

NEW DELHI: In an attempt to exercise greater control over content posted by independent news creators, the Centre proposes to extend IT rules to take into its ambit YouTubers, Instagram Reels creators, X (formerly Twitter) users, and other influencers with significant followings who are not 'publishers' but post or share news and current affairs content online.

The draft rules significantly expand government oversight of online content. "The Government of India remains committed to ensuring an open, safe, trusted and accountable internet for all users of internet-enabled services. The proposed amendments seek to strengthen compliance with clarifications, advisories and directions issued by the Ministry under Part II and to enhance the effectiveness of regulatory oversight of content regulation mechanisms under Part III (Code of Ethics relating to Digital Media) of the IT Rules, 2021," the Ministry of Electronic and Information Technology (MeitY) notification states.

It means that social media platforms will now have to comply with guidelines or advisories issued by the IT ministry or risk legal action. These are amendments proposed in the IT Rules, 2021 by the ministry, with a draft being released for public consultation on Monday. The ministry has invited feedback and comments from stakeholders on the proposed amendments by April 14, 2026.

The first change also



TAKEAWAYS

- » Amendments extend Code of Ethics to user-generated news content
- » Platforms hosting such content may be subject to stricter oversight
- » Three-tier regulatory mechanism may apply to non-publisher users
- » Social media platforms must follow IT Ministry advisories or face legal action
- » New Rule 3(4) mandates compliance with Ministry directions under due diligence
- » Data retention rules clarified to align with other applicable laws
- » MIB blocking powers expanded via Inter-Departmental Committee (IDC)
- » IDC can now examine "matters", not just formal complaints
- » Govt can initiate scrutiny without waiting for grievances

significantly expands the Information and Broadcasting Ministry's (MIB) blocking powers, including through the Inter Disciplinary Committee or IDC that hears cases. An ancillary change proposed is in how IDC functions, allowing it to take up "matters" as opposed to "complaints", thereby enabling it to weigh in on a broad and unspecified range of **Continued on P4**

Outsiders being added to Bengal poll list through Form 6: Mamata to CEC

OUR CORRESPONDENT

KOLKATA: Trinamool Congress (TMC) chairperson Mamata Banerjee, on Tuesday, wrote to Chief Election Commissioner (CEC) Gyanesh Kumar flagging her serious concern over credible reports regarding a large number of Form 6 applications being submitted by BJP agents at the office of the Chief Electoral Officer (CEO) and across several districts. Banerjee stated that such applications do not seem to be routine applications for voter inclusion but a mischievous ploy to include non-residents in the electoral roll.

"There are serious concerns that these applications may pertain to individuals who are not genuine residents of Bengal and have no legitimate connection to the state. Similar patterns were reportedly observed prior to elections in Bihar, Haryana, Maharashtra and Delhi. Such actions, if true, would be illegal, unconstitutional and fundamentally undemocratic, reflecting mala fide intent and ill motive. This is not the standard expected of a constitutional authority. The people have a right to transparency and to the protection of their voting rights," her letter read.

Continued on P4

GOLDEN YIELD



A woman harvests wheat in a field, in Prayagraj, on Wednesday

PTI

FIRE

OFF MULTIPLE THREAT EMAILS, SHIFTED BASE TO EVADE ARREST

Grudge against justice system led ex-academic to send 1,100 bomb threats

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: An ex-assistant professor now behind bars for allegedly making over 1,100 hoax bomb threats was reportedly furious with the legal justice system.

Srinivas Louis, 47, is presumed to be tech-savvy and employed multiple methods to conceal his IP address, making it difficult for agencies to trace the origin of the threatening e-mails, a senior police officer said.

Louis was apprehended on Saturday from his rented accommodation in Karnataka's Mysuru, after a series of coordinated investigations into bomb threat e-mails sent to schools, courts and government offices.

The accused used to fre-



quently change his name and residential address to evade police detection, the probe revealed.

Multiple states are now contacting the Delhi Police for his transit remand to interrogate Louis, the officer said.

A police source said that the accused would send threatening e-mails in quick succession, often targeting multiple institutions in a single day, and then shift his residence and assume a different identity to avoid being tracked or detained.

'The accused disclosed he harboured resentment towards judicial system due to a family land dispute in which his father did not receive a share'

During sustained interrogation, the accused disclosed that he harboured resentment towards the judicial system due to a family land dispute in which his father allegedly did not receive a share.

"This dissatisfaction with court proceedings is suspected to have driven him to repeatedly target judicial institutions with hoax threats," the source added.

Police said he not only sent e-mails within India but also targeted some cities in

Pakistan, indicating the wide geographical spread of his activities. Authorities are now working to link multiple FIRs registered in different states in connection with the threatening messages to the accused.

The accused is currently in police custody, and his mobile phone and other electronic devices have been sent for forensic examination, police said, adding that he will be taken to Mysuru to recover additional digital evidence and devices allegedly used in the commission of the offences.

"Further disclosures are expected following the forensic analysis, which may shed more light on the full extent of his activities and the techniques used to mask his digital footprint.

2 held after separate late-night shootouts

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: Two men wanted in connection with a fatal stabbing and multiple knife attacks in southwest Delhi's Dabri area were arrested after separate late-night police encounters, an official said on Tuesday.

The accused, identified as Rohit Kumar alias Noddy and Prem Sharma alias Himanshu, allegedly opened fire on police teams trying to apprehend them and were shot in the leg in retaliatory firing. Both have prior criminal records, police said.

The arrests came within 24 hours of two stabbing incidents reported from Madhu Vihar on Sunday night, in which one person was killed and three others critically injured. The incidents occurred within a span of around 15 minutes.

In the first case, 39-year-old Govind Jha, a food delivery agent, was stabbed to death near Durga Mata Mandir after



he asked the accused for directions. He later succumbed to injuries at a hospital.

Minutes later, three persons — Honey, Anish and Rohit — were stabbed near Nav Jeevan School. Two victims remain unfit for statement, while one was referred for specialised treatment.

Police ruled out any communal angle, calling such claims misleading.

Rohit Kumar was arrested near Dwarka Sector 17 with a pistol and cartridges, while Prem Sharma was held near Najafgarh on a stolen scooter. Sharma is the main accused in Jha's murder, police said.

Fbd: Food delivery agent on bike killed after being hit by Mercedes

FARIDABAD: A 28-year-old food delivery agent was killed after his bike was allegedly hit from behind by a speeding Mercedes in Sector 15 of Faridabad, police said on Tuesday.

The victim, Anand Raj Bind, a native of Mirzapur in Uttar Pradesh, had been living in Bhatola village and worked for Zomato. The accident occurred around 2 am on Monday near the fire brigade office.

Police said the impact flung him and his bike onto the road. His brother found him unconscious at the spot, with the car parked some distance away. He was first taken to a private hospital and later referred to Delhi, where he died during treatment. The driver fled the scene, leaving the vehicle behind, which has been seized. Police said the car, registered to a company, was headed to the airport at the time. Efforts are on to arrest the driver. **MPOST**

IFFD concludes with spl screenings

NEW DELHI: The International Film Festival Delhi 2026 concluded with special screenings of films "Shatak: Sangh ke 100 Varsh" and a short film on Ahilyabai Holkar at Bharat Mandapam, drawing large audiences and appreciation from film enthusiasts and dignitaries.

Delhi's Minister for Art, Culture and Tourism Kapil Mishra lauded the initiative, saying such films help younger generations understand the contributions of national figures. Highlighting the film on the Rashtriya Swayamsevak Sangh, he said it effectively presents its 100-year journey



and service to the nation.

Speaking at the event, Mishra said, "Prime Minister Narendra Modi has transformed Ram Temple, Kashi Vishwanath, Mahakal, Somnath, Kedarnath and Shri Krishna Janmabhoomi into grand structures," emphasising the role of cultural revival in nation-building.

He added, "Under the leadership of PM Narendra Modi, the resolutions of RSS and BJP are being fulfilled."

The minister also praised the legacy of Ahilyabai Holkar, noting her contribution to temple restoration and social reform. He said her leadership continues to inspire efforts toward preserving India's cultural heritage. IFFD 2026 concluded with special screenings, drawing global participation. Attendees said the festival fostered dialogue on culture, history and identity, while strengthening Delhi's position as an emerging hub for cinema and creative exchange. **MPOST**

CBI nabs MCD officer taking Rs 4 lakh bribe

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: The Central Bureau of Investigation (CBI) has arrested two senior Municipal Corporation of Delhi officials in connection with an alleged bribery case in the Shahdara North Zone.

The accused include Administrative Officer Devanshu Gautam and Deputy Commissioner Abhishek Mishra. The arrests followed coordinated raids after complaints from local business owners about demands for routine

approvals. On Tuesday, Gautam was charged with allegedly seeking Rs 4 lakh to influence an official report. The payment was purportedly routed on behalf of Mishra to secure favourable treatment.

Acting on the complaint, the CBI laid a trap and caught Gautam while allegedly accepting the bribe. Subsequent investigation indicated Mishra's involvement in the case. Both officials have been detained, and charges including criminal conspiracy and abuse of public office are likely. Further investigation is underway.

20-year-old nabbed for fatal stabbing after family dispute

PRAJYOT DEOGHARE

NEW DELHI: A 20-year-old man has been arrested for allegedly stabbing his 30-year-old brother-in-law following a family dispute in northeast Delhi's Nand Nagri area, police said.

The incident came to light on the night of March 29 after a PCR call alerted police, who later received information from Guru Teg Bahadur Hospital about an injured man admitted with stab wounds. A police team reached the hospital and found the victim, identified as



Neeraj, a resident of Tahirpur, undergoing treatment.

Based on the information, an FIR was registered under Section 109(1) of the Bharatiya Nyaya Sanhita at Nand Nagri Police Station and an investigation was launched. Preliminary enquiry revealed that the victim had been stabbed by his brother-in-law during an altercation.

The accused, identified as Ramesh, was traced and apprehended by a team led by SHO Inspector Anand Yadav. During interrogation, he allegedly confessed, stating the attack followed a heated argument over a family dispute.

At his instance, the police recovered the knife used in the offence. Neeraj later succumbed to his injuries, following which Section 103(1) BNS was added to the case.



Narendra Modi
Prime Minister







Rekha Gupta
Chief Minister

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Kamla Nagar gets L-G ATTENTION

Spots civic gaps, promises time-bound fixes

AIMAN FATIMA

NEW DELHI: Delhi Lieutenant Governor Taranjeet Singh Sandhu on Tuesday conducted an unscheduled visit to Kamla Nagar Market, interacting directly with residents, shopkeepers and students to assess long-standing civic concerns in the bustling North Delhi hub.

Walking through Bungalow Road and the main market stretch, the L-G observed issues related to parking, traffic congestion, sanitation, hanging wires and lack of public utilities. The market, located near Delhi University, remains a popular destination for students and visitors.

During his visit, Sandhu engaged with stakeholders including vendors, tourists and local residents, who raised concerns about safety, women's security and high rental costs in PG accommodations. Market associations also highlighted the underutilisation of an underground parking facility with a capacity of over 800 vehicles, developed by the Municipal Corporation of Delhi, attributing it to design flaws.

The L-G assured citizens that their concerns would be addressed promptly, stating that he would take up the issues with the concerned departments to ensure time-bound solutions. In a lighter moment, Sandhu also visited the popular eatery Chache Di Hatti, where he queued up with customers to enjoy chhole bhature. Sharing his experience later, he said, "Interacted with shopkeepers, workers, vendors, shoppers, tourists and



ON GROUND

» The L-G assured citizens that their concerns would be addressed promptly, stating that he would take up the issues with the concerned departments to ensure time-bound solutions

» In a lighter moment,

Sandhu also visited the popular eatery Chache Di Hatti, where he queued up with customers to enjoy chhole bhature

» The visit reflected the L-G's continued focus on direct public outreach and ground-level assessment of civic infrastructure

students - who continue to throng 'K-Nag' with the same vibrant energy. Even managed to savour the ever popular Chache Di Hatti Chhole Bhature." The visit reflected the L-G's continued focus on direct

public outreach and ground-level assessment of civic infrastructure, especially in high-footfall areas like Kamla Nagar, which remains a key commercial and social hub in the Capital.

MCD gives Tax Amnesty more time

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: The Municipal Corporation of Delhi has extended the last date of availing the Property Tax Amnesty Scheme 2025-26 till April 30, the Delhi Mayor said on Tuesday.

Announcing the extension, Mayor Raja Iqbal Singh said the decision was taken in

view of the positive response from citizens and to allow more taxpayers to settle their pending dues under the Sumpatiktak Niptaan Yojana (SUNIYO) scheme.

He urged property owners and occupiers to make use of the scheme, describing it as a "golden opportunity" to clear outstanding liabilities without incurring interest or penalties.

The mayor said that the scheme will not be extended beyond April 30. Under SUNIYO, taxpayers can avail a complete waiver of property tax, interest and penalties for the period prior to 2020-21, provided they pay the principal tax amount for the current financial year 2025-26 and the preceding five years from 2020-21 to 2024-25.

Govt to construct 2.7-km protection wall along Mungeshpur drain

NEW DELHI: The Delhi irrigation and flood control department plans to construct a wall stretching over nearly three kilometres for protection against flooding along the Mungeshpur drain in the Outer Delhi area, officials said on Tuesday.

Last year, a section of the drain was damaged, letting water into villages and colonies situated near the Haryana border. People living in the low-lying areas were evacuated as a result. Delhi Chief Minister Rekha Gupta had spoken with her Haryana counterpart about the rescue operation.

"The work will be carried out along both the left and right sides of the bank of the Mungeshpur drain. The inspection road along the bank will also be repaired, and its height will be increased. A tender has been issued for this," an official said.

Ahead of the monsoon season, the department will carry out this work at the cost of over Rs 4.3 crore, according to the official, which will include the 2.7-kilometre wall.

The irrigation and flood control department is also taking up a similar project - construction of a five-kilometre protection wall along the Yamuna river from Majnu Ka Tila to Kashmere Gate area. The project is being planned to protect residential areas along the Ring Road, which have seen flooding in the past monsoon season when the water level was high.

According to officials, approval has been given to the Mungeshpur wall project, and the work is expected to be completed in six months, after awarding of the project. PTI

DJB to add over 400 tubewells

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: Amid an increasing demand of water connections in the city, the Delhi Jal Board (DJB) has planned to increase the number of tubewells by more than 400 this year.

The number of water connections has increased in the previous year and is expected to increase further, keeping this in mind, infrastructure enhancements are being made to cater to the demand, officials said.

According to the summer action plan, this year DJB plans to increase its total tally of tubewells to 6,290 from the previous year of 5,834 tubewells, an increase of 456, increasing its groundwater extraction by 10 million gallons per day (MGD).



The move comes in response to a steady rise in water demand across Delhi, driven by an increase in total water connections. Data from the latest economic survey indicates that connections rose from 28.35 lakh in 2023-24 to 28.99 lakh in 2024-25, reflecting an increase of nearly 64,000 households.

"Further the government is also exploring the installation of tubewells in the area adjacent to

CM Rekha rejects Pink Card time gap claim

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: Chief Minister Rekha Gupta on Tuesday rejected claims that the 'Saheli Pink Card' for free bus travel to women residents can be used again only one hour after it has been tapped as "lies" and "propaganda."

She stressed that the new mobility cards are working with full efficiency, providing free travel to women and transgender residents of Delhi on buses.

"A rumour is being spread that if you tap your pink card once in a bus and then you get



off and board another bus, then the card does not work. These are complete lies and political propaganda," she said in a

video message in a post on X. Earlier this month, the Pink National Common Mobility (PNCM) card was launched by

President Droupadi Murmu. More than 1 lakh cards have been distributed till now, officials said.

Gupta also said that travellers can use the Pink Card in "gaps of 5, 10 and 15 minutes" and that women can travel as many times as they want for free.

Under the scheme, the BJP government has replaced the pink paper ticketing system launched by the previous AAP government in 2019 by the Centre's 'One Nation, One Card' initiative through the Pink NCMC card, allowing free travel only for Delhi residents.

Chief Minister Gupta had said that the card will also enable seamless paid access to the Metro, Regional Rapid Transit System (RRTS) and other public transport services through a single smart card.

According to officials, the facility will be implemented on the same pattern and mechanism as the free travel scheme currently available for women passengers in Delhi buses.

The Delhi government has set up 50 authorised centres across the city to facilitate the issuance of the Saheli Pink smart cards.

MCD Standing panel: Nine members retire

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: Nine councillors of MCD's Standing Committee, the top executive and decision-making body of the corporation, retired on Tuesday after being selected through a draw of lots as part of the rotation process mandated under the Delhi Municipal Corporation (DMC) Act.

Although the retirement is part of the procedure, the situation has left approval of contracts to manage garbage in South, Central and West zones worth Rs 2,939 crore in limbo.

The proposal was set to be tabled in this meeting. Officials said that another proposal to set up a medical college in north Delhi was to be taken up in the meeting but it will now be taken up in the next meeting after the re-election of the nine members is complete.

According to the outcome, six ward committee members and three House members were excluded by the draw. Of these, six members belong to the BJP and three to AAP. Now in the composition, five councillors from the BJP and four from AAP remain in the committee.

Among those excluded, one member from the House and five from ward committees are from the BJP while AAP saw two members from the House and one from a ward committee being left out.

Shikha Bharadwaj, Indrajeet Sehrawat, Rajpal Singh, Anju Devi, Nema Bhagat and Pankaj Luthra of the BJP, and Ankush Narang, Mohini Jeenwal and Amil Malik of AAP are the nine councillors who exited the standing committee via draw of lots on Tuesday.

The members who retired from ward committees are Shikha Bharadwaj, Anju Devi, Indrajeet Sehrawat, Rajpal Singh and Neema Bhagat of the BJP, and Ankush Narang of AAP.

Those who retired from among members elected by the House are Pankaj Luthra of the BJP, and Mohini Jeenwal and Aamil Malik of AAP.

Meanwhile, Praveen Kumar, AAP councillor and member of the Standing Committee of the Municipal Corporation of Delhi (MCD) raised objections over both alleged irregularities in the civic body's town planning wing and the procedure followed in convening a committee meeting. Leader of Opposition and AAP councillor Ankush Narang said that without the agenda item 52, a pending issue from February 18 was being formally passed on Tuesday.

In a letter to the commissioner, Councillor Praveen Kumar flagged what he described as serious irregularities in the office of the chief town planner, including alleged rule violations in housing conversions, delays in approvals and undue benefits to select individuals.

He sought an independent probe by central vigilance agencies, saying a departmental inquiry would not be sufficient.

In a separate communication to the standing committee chairperson, Kumar questioned the legality of a meeting scheduled for March 31 at 1 pm.

He said, "The previous meeting held on March 30 was adjourned without announcing the next date, making the new meeting a 'fresh' one that required a mandatory 72-hour notice under the rules."



A metro train passes by as rain clouds fill the evening sky, in Gurugram, Tuesday

PTI

March goes out with a splash

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: Cloudy skies and spells of rain greeted Delhi residents on Tuesday as the national capital remained under a yellow alert, even as temperatures stayed above normal with the maximum touching 33.7 degrees Celsius.

The India Meteorological Department has issued a yellow alert, indicating "be updated", with a generally cloudy sky and intermittent very light to light rain accompanied by thunderstorms, lightning and strong surface winds of 20-30 kmph, gusting up to 40 kmph during the evening and night.

Rainfall recorded between 2.30 pm and 5.30 pm stood at 2.1 mm at Safdarjung, 2.6 mm at Palam, 2.8 mm at Lodi Road, 2.4 mm at Ridge and 2.2 mm at Ayanagar. Among other stations, Janakpuri recorded the highest rainfall at 4 mm, while Pusa and Mayur Vihar received 2 mm each and Pitampura recorded 1.5 mm.

Maximum temperatures across stations remained in a similar range above normal,

This was the wettest March as well in the last three years

with Safdarjung recording 33.7 degrees Celsius, Palam 33.2 degrees, Lodi Road 33.2 degrees, Ridge 33.9 degrees and Ayanagar 33.8 degrees.

Minimum temperatures showed slight variation, with Safdarjung at 19.4 degrees Celsius, Palam at 19.6 degrees, Lodi Road at 18.0 degrees, Ridge at 18.4 degrees and Ayanagar at 18.6 degrees.

The weather office has forecast a minimum temperature of 18 degrees Celsius and a maximum of 34 degrees Celsius for Wednesday, with partly cloudy skies.

The air quality stood in the 'moderate' category with an AQI of 171, according to the Central Pollution Control Board (CPCB). The Air Quality Early Warning System has forecast that air quality is likely to remain in the 'moderate' category from April 1 to 3.

As per CPCB standards,

an AQI of 0-50 is considered 'good', 51-100 'satisfactory', 101-200 'moderate', 201-300 'poor', 301-400 'very poor', and 401-500 'severe'.

As the month comes to an end, Delhi recorded its most polluted March in four years in 2026, with the average Air Quality Index (AQI) at 181 till March 30, the highest since 2022, when it stood at 217, according to an analysis by Centre for Research on Energy and Clean Air.

The month was also among the hottest in the past four years as the average maximum temperature stood at 32.6 degrees Celsius - highest in four years. The last time the average maximum temperature was higher in March was in 2022, when it reached 33.4 degrees Celsius.

This was the wettest March as well in the last three years. Rainfall recorded this month was 19.82 mm - the highest for the month since 2023, when rainfall was significantly higher at 50.4 mm, while rainfall in 2024 and 2025 remained lower than the 2026 levels.

City Briefs

NDMC TO INSTITUTIONALISE 'SHAKTI' ART WORKSHOP, ANNOUNCES SCULPTURE PARK

NEW DELHI: The New Delhi Municipal Council on Tuesday said it will institutionalise its women-focused art workshop 'Shakti' as an annual cultural programme, while also announcing plans to set up a sculpture park at Nehru Park. The announcement came as the five-day workshop, organised in collaboration with Triveni Kala Sangam, concluded with an exhibition showcasing works by 20 women artists from across India. Held from March 27 to 31, the workshop centred on the theme of Shakti, exploring feminine power, identity and resilience through contemporary artistic practices.

TRAFFIC CURBS ON CENTRAL DELHI ROAD AMID UNDERGROUND CABLE WORK

NEW DELHI: Traffic movement will remain affected in central Delhi's Paharganj due to ongoing underground cabling maintenance work on New Rohtak Road between Kamal T Point and Liberty Cinema on Tuesday, an official said. According to an advisory issued by the Delhi Traffic Police, two lanes on the stretch have been closed, leading to expected congestion and slow movement between 2 pm and 11 pm. The work, being carried out by Tata Power Delhi Distribution Limited (TPDDL) at Anand Parbat, is likely to impact commuters heading towards the central parts of the city. Authorities have advised motorists to avoid the affected stretch during the specified hours and use alternate routes.

GOVT ASKS OFFICES TO COMPLETE WIDOW PENSION VERIFICATION IN BY APR 15

NEW DELHI: The Delhi government has directed its district offices to complete the verification of beneficiaries under the Indira Gandhi National Widow Pension Scheme (IGN-WPS) by April 15 using a mobile-based digital application, according to an official order. Issued by the Department of Women and Child Development on Monday, the order mandates verification through the Digital Life Certificate application, also known as the Beneficiary Satyapan App (BSA), in line with directives from the Ministry of Rural Development by April 15. The verification process has been initiated under the National Social Assistance Programme to ensure that beneficiaries are authenticated in a systematic and timely manner, it said.

Haryana, Punjab lashed by rain and hailstorm; wheat growers fear damage

The IMD also reported weather-related fatalities in March, with 32 deaths due to lightning across several states. Additional casualties included four deaths from thunderstorms in Bihar and Odisha, and in Jammu and Kashmir, seven deaths from snowfall along with two fatalities linked to floods and heavy rainfall.

Iran war: PM says India acted swiftly; slams Congress as 'political vultures'




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Delhi (New Delhi Municipal Council and Delhi Cantonment Board)

Self-Enumeration 1st – 15th April	Houselisting 16th April – 15th May
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Delhi (Municipal Corporation of Delhi)

Self-Enumeration 1st – 15th May	Houselisting 16th May – 14th June
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RISE, REIGN AND FALL OF NAXALISM

Chhattisgarh’s red corridor finally hits dead end

OUR CORRESPONDENT

RAIPUR: More than four decades after the first “dalams” crossed into the forests of Dandakaranya, present-day Bastar, the sun has set on the armed Maoist rebellion in Chhattisgarh, as the region was on Tuesday declared free of Left-Wing Extremism (LWE) on the deadline set by the Centre.

In the 1980s, Maoists entered Bastar, intending to use it as a backyard or hideout amid intensified pressure from the police in neighbouring Andhra Pradesh.

What began as a small, ideologically driven movement more than 40 years ago metamorphosed into an armed rebellion, before entering a phase of sustained decline that has reshaped Chhattisgarh’s security and governance landscape.

Experts say the trajectory of Naxalism in the region can be summarised in three phases: its gradual entry and expansion from the 1980s, the peak of insurgency between 2004 and 2014 following the formation of CPI (Maoist), and the sustained decline witnessed over the past decade.

HIGHLIGHTS

» In 1980s, Maoists entered Bastar, intending to use it as backyard or hideout amid intensified pressure from police in Andhra

» The Bastar division, which now comprises seven districts, was a single district then, spanning approximately 40,000 sq km, larger than Kerala

Speaking to the news agency, Sundarraj Pattinglam, Inspector General (Bastar Range), noted that Maoists initially took advantage of geographical isolation, limited governance reach, and socio-economic vulnerabilities to establish networks in remote forest areas of Chhattisgarh.

The 2003-batch IPS officer has been leading the anti-Maoist operations in the Bastar range for the last nine years.

“Over the last decade, a sustained and coordinated strategy — combining focused security operations, strengthened intelligence, expansion of security camps, improved connectivity, and effective surrender-cum-rehabilitation policies — has significantly weakened the Maoist ecosystem,” he said.

Girishkant Pandey, a security analyst and princi-

pal of a government college at Nawagarh in Bemetara district, said the Naxal movement in Bastar traces its origins to 1980.

The Bastar division, which now comprises seven districts, was a single district then, spanning approximately 40,000 sq km, larger than Kerala.

On April 22, 1980, Kondapalli Sitaramaiah, a government school teacher from undivided Andhra Pradesh, founded the Communist Party of India-Marxist-Leninist — Peoples’ War Group (CPI (M-L) PWG), coinciding with the birth anniversary of Russian Revolutionary Vladimir Lenin.

Although Naxalism began with the Naxalbari Uprising in 1967 in West Bengal, it was in the 1980s that the movement gained significant ground in Bastar.

Chhattisgarh: 35 Naxalites surrender in hours before Centre-set deadline

RAIPUR: A total of 35 Naxalites surrendered before security forces across five districts in Chhattisgarh’s Bastar region on Tuesday, just hours before the Centre’s March 31 deadline to eliminate Left Wing Extremism (LWE) ends, officials said.

Of them, 25 cadres, including 12 women, belonging to the Dandakaranya Special Zonal Committee (DKSZC) of Maoists, surrendered in Bijapur district under the police’s ‘Poona Margem’ (from rehabilitation to social reintegration) initiative, Inspector General of Police (IGP) of Bastar Range, Sundarraj Pattinglam, said.

MPOST

ITBP to partner with HP govt for procurements from local farmers

ASHWANI SHARMA

SHIMLA: In a landmark initiative, the Indo-Tibetan Border Police (ITBP) has decided to join hands with the Himachal Pradesh government for the procurement of locally produced fresh vegetables, fruits, milk, paneer, meat, trout fish, and other agricultural products.

The ITBP will sign an MOU with the government to directly source produce from farmers, cooperative societies, and local producers.

The initiative aims to provide farmers with a reliable market within their own villages, thereby enhancing income opportunities and reducing dependency on intermediaries. The move is expected to generate employment for farmers, horticulturists, and rural communities residing in border areas while also contributing to inclusive and sustainable regional development.

Chief Minister Sukhvirinder Singh Sukhu on Monday held a detailed meeting with senior ITBP officials, including Northern Frontier Commander IG Manu Maharaj and Sector Commander DIG Pawan Kumar Negi, to deliberate on the modalities of the proposed collaboration.

CM Sukhu rolls back entry fee following protests

OUR CORRESPONDENT

SHIMLA: With protests growing on the state’s borders and also within the state, Himachal Pradesh Chief Minister Sukhvirinder Singh Sukhu on Tuesday ordered a partial rollback of the hiked entry fee on the vehicles coming to the state.

He announced a reduction in the fee for certain categories of vehicles under the state’s new toll tax policy.

The protesters had threatened to block all entry points to the state from midnight today.

“We have decided to revise the entry fee for both five-seater and six- to 12-seater four-wheelers to Rs 100, reduced from the earlier proposed Rs 130. There had been some confusion regarding the fee structure, as both categories were brought under a single entry fee. We have now clarified that the entry fee for both types of vehicles will be Rs 100,” Sukhu told Millennium Post in Shimla.

‘E-Bhoomi portal for Tosham IMT to be opened next week’

MPOST BUREAU

CHANDIGARH: Haryana Chief Minister Nayab Singh Saini said that while Congress election promises during its regime were never implemented and remained confined to announcements that “ended up in dustbins,” the BJP-led double-engine government since 2014 has ensured that every election Sankalp is being fulfilled on the ground in a time-bound, transparent and accountable manner. He said the present government is not a promise-making administration but a delivery-oriented governance model, where every Sankalp is translated into action with commitment and speed.

The Chief Minister was addressing the Unnat Sinchai Utsav–2026 organised at Tosham in Bhiwani district on Tuesday. Upon arrival, he paid floral tributes to former Chief Minister late Chaudhary Bansilal and late Chaudhary Sunder Singh.

SATYAPRAKASH SHARMA

NEW DELHI: In a landmark move to boost religious tourism and temple administration, the Shri Kashi Vishwanath Temple Trust and the Shri Mahakaleswar Temple Management Committee signed an MoU on Tuesday in Varanasi, in the presence of Madhya Pradesh Chief Minister Mohan Yadav, to share best practices in temple management and enhance facilities for pilgrims visiting the iconic Jyotirlingas.

Madhya Pradesh and Uttar Pradesh also signed another significant Memorandum of Understanding (MoU) during the MP-UP Sahyog Sammelan, aimed at accelerating economic growth through the One District One Product (ODOP) initiative. Addressing the event, CM Yadav said the MoU inked between both shrines will facilitate the exchange of best practices in temple administration and pilgrimage management.

The CM said the agreement



MP Chief Minister Mohan Yadav performs puja at Kashi Vishwanath Jyotirlinga, in Varanasi on Tuesday

MPOST

builds on the transformation witnessed in Kashi and Mahakaleswar under the leadership of Prime Minister Narendra Modi. The large-scale infrastructure upgrades in Varanasi and Ujjain have led to a surge in religious tourism, significantly impacting local economies, he said.

“The MoU will enable both

sides to share administrative expertise and improve pilgrim facilities, leveraging the similarities in scale and spiritual significance of the two temple towns,” Yadav said.

Yadav said the MoU on the ODOP programme will strengthen the initiative, with a focus on enhancing the branding,

stagnation, the Chief Minister outlined a governance model that combines industry-aligned skill training in cutting-edge fields such as Robotics, Electric Vehicles, Solar Technology and Drone Training, expanded access to technical education including for women, and large-scale water augmentation equivalent to the Bhakra Canal to strengthen Punjab’s agrarian backbone.

Positioning the development push alongside a political contrast, CM Mann asserted that those who presided over the rise of the drug trade and

Personal data isn’t collected: MHA

Over security agencies using open-source intelligence from public sources including the social media

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: The home ministry has told a Parliamentary panel that security agencies use open-source intelligence from public sources, including social media, to gather information, emphasising that no privacy breach occurs as personal data isn’t collected.

The ministry’s submission was made to the Standing Committee on Communications and Information Technology (2024-25), chaired by Lok Sabha member Nishikant Dubey, which tabled its report on Monday.

The committee had sought to know from the ministry how it dealt with the issue of privacy while scraping through the internet and through social media.

“Publicly available information on the internet and social media platforms is used for intelligence gathering. No private or personal information is gathered from social media. Hence, privacy is never violated,” the ministry told the panel.

Scraping generally refers to the use of computer programmes, tools or software (called web scrapers) to automatically browse public web pages or social media posts; extract specific information

CLOSER LOOK

» The ministry’s submission was made to Standing Committee on Communications and Information Technology (2024-25)

» Committee had sought to know from ministry how it dealt with issue of privacy while scraping through internet and through social media

(e.g., names, phone numbers, keywords, hashtags, trends, images); store or analyse that information for law enforcement or intelligence purposes, it said.

The ministry said the type of data that can be scraped by the authorised security agencies only from publicly available sources using open-source intelligence technique may include social media posts like public tweets, Facebook posts, YouTube videos, deepfakes or morphed media, fake news or misinformation, including viral instigating content spreading communal hatred.

The scraping may be used to collect hashtags and trends, for example, from YouTube chan-

nels and Telegram groups, for radical content and posts that promote extremist ideologies or share propaganda videos or bomb-making tutorials.

It said the technique may be used to monitor scam websites or links to track, for example, online gambling, fake job scams, and fake investment scams.

It may be used on matrimonial and dating Platforms for honey traps or fraud, and from dark web marketplaces for the extraction of cryptocurrency wallet addresses, it said, giving examples of the process.

“Public profiles on matrimonial/dating sites may be scraped in cybercrime investigations where people are blackmailed or trapped into sharing sensitive data,” it said while giving examples.

The ministry told the panel that AI is being used for intelligence gathering and counter-intelligence, with key applications including face recognition, social media parsing and network analysis, natural language processing for analysis of structured and unstructured data, pattern analysis and hidden connections, etc.

“Additionally, AI is used for entity resolution, enabling accurate identification and correlation of individuals across multiple data sources,” it said.

North India’s first ‘Glass Bridge’ to be built over Nangal Lake: Mann

MPOST BUREAU

CHANDIGARH: Amid an aggressive push to transform Nangal into a hub of modern infrastructure, skill development and tourism, Punjab Chief Minister Bhagwant Mann rolled out a ₹75 crore development package, anchored by North India’s first Glass Bridge, a ₹23 crore Centre of Excellence named after Kargil martyr Captain Amol Kalia, and major upgrades in education infrastructure.

Declaring these initiatives as a decisive break from years of



Bhagwant Mann

weakened Punjab’s social fabric can never be forgiven, stating that the people of the state have moved decisively towards a model of honest governance

focused on jobs, education and infrastructure.

After dedicating development works worth ₹75 crore to the people, Punjab CM stated, “The Akalis should be booked for the genocide of generations as the drug trade was patronised by them and flourished during their long misrule. The hands of these leaders are drenched with the blood of millions of youth who fell prey to drugs supplied in the state in their official vehicles. These sins are unpardonable and they can never be forgiven by the people for their long saga of

misdeeds.”

Coming down heavily on the Akali leadership, Mann asserted, “These are opportunist leaders who change their colours and stance like a chameleon as per their convenience and vested political interests. They have long fooled people by calling themselves farmers, but can they explain how any food grower acquires a huge fleet of buses and a lavish hotel in Gurugram? All this has been accumulated by selling the interests of the state and its people for their vested political gains.”

Supply & price concerns: UP govt puts on hold writing expiry dates on eggs

BISWAJEET BANERJEE

LUCKNOW: The Uttar Pradesh government has put on hold the implementation of mandatory expiry date labelling on eggs, citing concerns over a potential supply disruption and a sharp rise in prices.

Officials in the Food Safety and Drug Administration said enforcing the rule at this stage could lead to an immediate shortage, as a significant portion of eggs consumed in the state comes from outside and is not stamped with production or expiry dates.

Uttar Pradesh consumes around 3.35 crore eggs daily, while local production stands at about 1.80 crore. The remaining 1.55 crore eggs are sourced from states such as Haryana, Punjab, Telan-



gana, Andhra Pradesh and Tamil Nadu. Eggs supplied from these states are typically stamped only for export, not for domestic trade.

Authorities said that if the rule is enforced strictly, unstamped eggs from these states would not be allowed to be sold in Uttar Pradesh markets, which could severely disrupt supply and push up prices.

Officials also flagged logistical challenges in implementing the rule. Eggs would need to be stamped with production and expiry dates immediately after

being laid, making it difficult to manage sorting, storage and distribution. Variations in storage conditions further complicate the process, as eggs have a longer shelf life under refrigeration compared to room temperature.

The government is now planning to consult major supplier states before taking a final call on the issue.

The decision has, however, drawn criticism from industry representatives. VP Singh, president of the Uttar Pradesh Poultry Development Committee, alleged that the delay is due to pressure from large traders and said the state should have coordinated with supplier states to ensure compliance with the rule introduced by the Centre in February 2023.

Surat: Four women, child dead as fire breaks out at house

SURAT: Four women and a child were killed after a fire broke out in a three-storey house in Gujarat’s Surat city on Tuesday morning, police said.

The incident occurred in the Miithi Khadi locality under Limbayat police station area at around 10 am, when a family was busy packing sarees using foam sheets.

Fire brigade teams and ambulances rushed to the spot soon after the blaze was reported and carried out a rescue operation, Deputy Commissioner of Police (DCP) Kanan Desai said.

According to Desai, the fire broke out in a three-storey house that the occupants used for saree packing work.

“Since today is a holiday, they had brought a large amount of material for packing. After being alerted, the police, fire brigade and 108 emergency service personnel reached the spot immediately,” she said.

AGENCIES

‘Dynamic administrator’: CJI Surya Kant praises Ladakh L-G Saxena

NEW DELHI: During his recent visit to Leh, Chief Justice of India (CJI) Surya Kant showered praise on Ladakh’s Lieutenant General (L-G) VK Saxena.

CJI Kant was recently in Ladakh to inaugurate the district court complexes in Leh and Kargil, as well as the office of the Legal Services Authority, according to Bar and Bench.

“Your Lieutenant Governor is dynamic. He has passion for it. Now that he is here as administrator, it can really do wonders,” CJI Kant said.

He praised the L-G on March 28 while in conversation with Leh’s Chief Horticulture Officer Kunzang Wangmo. In the exchange captured on camera after tree planting at the court complex, the CJI and Wangmo spoke about the harmful effects of fertilisers.

“The best part is organic, natural. In most parts of the country, people are using so much spray and chemicals,” CJI Kant told Wangmo.

Addressing L-G Saxena later, CJI said:

“Your Chief Horticulture Officer, she is also very com-



CJI Surya Kant being received by Ladakh L-G Vinai Kumar Saxena, in Leh

PTI

mitted. I just told her that you are fortunate to have such a dynamic administrator.”

A video of the inauguration of the Leh District Complex and the CJI’s informal conversation with Wangmo has been uploaded by a local media channel called ‘Reach Ladakh’ on YouTube.

CJI had arrived in Leh on March 27 and was welcomed at the airport by L-G Saxena, Jammu & Kashmir and Ladakh High Court Chief Justice Arun Palli and others.

On March 28, he inaugurated the court complex in Leh. A day later, he also inaugurated the newly constructed District Court Complex at Kargil from the conference hall of Hotel Grand Dragon, Leh.

AGENCIES



EDITORIAL
COLLAPSE
OF WTO
CONSENSUS

The failure of World Trade Organisation (WTO) members to reach a consensus on extending the moratorium on non-violation complaints (NVCs) under the Agreement on Trade-related Aspects of Intellectual Property Rights (TRIPS) marks a quiet but consequential rupture in the global trade architecture. For nearly three decades, this moratorium had functioned as a stabilising cushion, preventing countries from being dragged into disputes even when they were fully compliant with WTO rules. Its lapse, following the inconclusive outcome of the 14th Ministerial Conference (MC14), introduces a new layer of uncertainty into an already strained multilateral system. At a time when global cooperation is fraying and economic nationalism is on the rise, the inability to preserve even such a foundational safeguard signals deeper fault lines between developed and developing economies.

At the heart of the issue lies the concept of non-violation complaints—an unusual provision in WTO law that allows a country to challenge another even when no formal rule has been breached. The complainant needs only to demonstrate that it has been deprived of an expected benefit due to another country's actions. While this mechanism exists across WTO agreements, its application to intellectual property has always been treated with caution. Recognising the risks of subjective interpretation and potential misuse, members had consistently agreed since 1995 to suspend such complaints under TRIPS. This ensured that countries could exercise policy flexibility—particularly in sensitive areas like public health—without the fear of litigation. With the moratorium now expired, that protective buffer has been removed, opening the door to disputes based not on violations but on perceived economic losses.

The implications are especially significant for countries like India, where intellectual property policy has been carefully calibrated to balance innovation with public interest. Provisions such as Section 3(d) of the Indian Patents Act, which prevents the ever-greening of pharmaceutical patents through minor modifications, are fully compliant with TRIPS. Similarly, tools like compulsory licensing allow governments to ensure affordable access to essential medicines. These are not legal loopholes but integral features of the agreement itself. Yet, in the absence of the moratorium, even such legitimate actions could be challenged on the grounds that they diminish the expected profits of foreign firms. The risk is not merely of adverse rulings, but of a broader chilling effect—where governments hesitate to use available flexibilities for fear of prolonged litigation and diplomatic pressure.

The divide between developed and developing countries on this issue reflects a deeper contest over the purpose of global intellectual property rules. Advanced economies, led by the United States and the European Union, argue that allowing non-violation complaints would strengthen IP protection and provide greater certainty to investors and innovators. For them, predictability in returns is essential to sustaining research and development. Developing countries, however, view the matter through a different lens. For nations grappling with public health challenges, food security concerns, and technological gaps, policy space is not a luxury but a necessity. The ability to regulate patents, promote domestic industries, and ensure access to affordable technologies is central to their development strategies. Non-violation complaints, by their very nature, introduce ambiguity into this space, tilting the balance in favour of corporate interests over sovereign policymaking.

Beyond pharmaceuticals, the potential scope of such disputes is far wider. Policies related to seeds, agriculture, biotechnology and industrial technologies could all come under scrutiny. In each of these domains, governments rely on TRIPS flexibilities to navigate the complex interplay between innovation and equity. The lapse of the moratorium thus raises concerns not only about immediate legal risks but also about the long-term trajectory of development policy in the Global South. Compounding this is the broader erosion of trust within the WTO system, where negotiations have increasingly struggled to deliver consensus outcomes. For years, developing countries had accepted compromises in areas like digital trade, including the continuation of a moratorium on customs duties for electronic transmissions, in exchange for safeguards such as protection from TRIPS-related disputes. The current impasse disrupts that delicate equilibrium.

What emerges, therefore, is not merely a technical disagreement but a structural shift in the global trade environment. Even if the issue returns to the negotiating table in Geneva, the interim period is fraught with uncertainty. The possibility that countries may begin to test the waters by filing non-violation complaints cannot be ruled out. Even a handful of such cases could reshape the risk calculus for governments, discouraging proactive policy interventions in critical sectors. For India, this moment calls for both vigilance and strategic clarity. Strengthening domestic legal preparedness, building coalitions with like-minded countries, and pushing for a swift restoration of the moratorium must be immediate priorities. More broadly, it underscores the need to reimagine global trade governance in a manner that recognises development imperatives alongside commercial interests. In the final analysis, intellectual property regimes cannot be divorced from questions of equity and access. If the balance tilts too far in favour of protection without flexibility, the very legitimacy of the system risks being undermined.

BHARAT
KI SOCH



ANIL RAJPUT
THE WRITER IS
CHAIRPERSON
BHARAT KI SOCH

Kumbhkarana demonstrates how leadership is not only about authority, but about the courage to advise, the humility to listen and the resolve to act

Leadership Anchored in Duty

Kumbhkarana's role in the Ramayana reveals a powerful leadership ethic—speak truth without fear, accept decisions with discipline and act with unwavering responsibility

"O King, I have spoken what is for your good, do with it as you see fit. But the deed you have already done has set its course, and I shall stand with you to face its consequence."
- Valmiki Ramayana, Yuddha Kanda

In moments of uncertainty in corporate governance, leadership is not defined only by those who command, but equally by those who counsel, dissent, and yet commit to loyalty when decisions are made. Within the vast narrative of the Ramayana, Kumbhkarana emerges in precisely such a role when he is called upon to defend an action he considered immoral. His role is neither dramatic nor overpowering, but is marked by rare clarity. He evaluates the situation objectively and without illusion, speaks with candour, and then dedicates himself fully to the path ahead. This brief but powerful narrative offers a distinctive insight into leadership, where one is entrusted with responsibility, choices are constrained, and character is required to align conviction with duty.

Kumbhkarana, recognised for his physical might and legendary slumber, enters the narrative at a moment of crisis when Lanka stands on the brink of war. His first instinct is neither aggression nor blind allegiance, but inquiry. He seeks to understand not merely what must be done, but how the situation has arisen. Upon learning that Ravana has abducted Sita and held her captive, he responds with unambiguous clarity. He identifies the act as a moral transgression and a strategic error made by Ravana that has put the kingdom in peril and exposed it to inevitable conflict. He urges Ravana to return Sita and seek reconciliation with Ram, emphasising that war would lead to ruin. In a court where many choose silence or validation, Kumbhkarana speaks with honesty and sincerity, placing institutional welfare above personal loyalty.

This moment reveals the first principle that directly addresses leadership. The strength of a leader does not lie merely in the authority



Kumbhkarana's actions reflect a dual ethic—freedom to dissent and discipline to execute

to decide, but in the willingness to listen and reflect on counsel. Yet Ravana does not take Kumbhkarana's advice well. He rebukes him sharply, accusing him of speaking like an adversary rather than a loyal brother. His response is driven less by reason and more by ego, and he sees the counsel as a challenge to his authority. Decisions are not diminished by reconsideration; they are strengthened by it. Ravana's failure is not merely the act of abduction, but the refusal to reassess it even when confronted with reasoned advice. In doing so, authority ceases to serve the institution and begins to serve itself.

The danger here is subtle but profound. When leaders begin to equate dissent with disloyalty and agreement with alignment, they create environments where truth is filtered before it is spoken. Advice then loses its corrective function and becomes ceremonial. Kumbhkarana's counsel, however, demonstrates that the value of insight does not depend on hierarchy or convenience, but on its alignment with dharma and institutional welfare. A leader's responsibility, therefore, is not merely to receive advice but to actively evaluate it, even after a decision has been made.

Yet the Ramayana does not present Kumbhkarana solely as a

voice of counsel. It presents him as a complete participant within an institutional structure. Having advised Ravana with honesty and candour, he accepts a second, equally demanding responsibility. Ravana's decision to wage war stands. The course is set. He does not contest the decision nor withdraw from his responsibilities. Instead, he aligns himself with the role he has been assigned and enters the battlefield, fully aware of the consequences of fighting a formidable adversary, and committed to performing his duty with resolve and dignity.

This introduces the second principle that addresses the role of the team player within an organisation. The obligation to offer advice is fundamental, but so is the obligation to respect the final decision once it is made. Institutional coherence and integrity depend not only on the quality of leadership but on the discipline of those who support it. Kumbhkarana neither withholds his counsel nor abandons his responsibility. He embodies a balance that is often misunderstood—the ability to dissent with clarity, and yet execute with commitment. It is this duality that elevates him beyond mere strength, positioning him as a figure who understands that leadership is not only about being right but also about standing firm in

responsibility when the moment demands it.

Modern organisational life frequently struggles to maintain this balance. Either advice is subordinated in the interest of conformity, or disagreement evolves into conflict and withdrawal from responsibility. Kumbhkarana demonstrates a more demanding standard: to speak truth when required, without fear or dilution, and to act with full commitment once direction is established. This dual responsibility preserves both integrity and cohesion, ensuring that institutions are neither weakened by silence nor fractured by dissent.

The legendary slumber of Kumbhkarana also offers a nuanced leadership insight—the discipline of measured engagement. In a world that often equates leadership with constant visibility and uninterrupted activity, Kumbhkarana's pattern suggests the opposite: that effectiveness is not diminished by periods of withdrawal, but often strengthened by them. His long intervals of inactivity are followed by moments of exceptional lucidity, decisiveness, and impact, indicating a capacity that is preserved, consolidated, and then deployed with precision. For leaders, this translates into the ability to step back from continuous motion, invest in reflection and renewal, and engage only when it truly mat-

ters, thereby ensuring that action, when taken, is both deliberate and consequential. Performance is thus measured not through perpetual activity, but through periods of withdrawal, preparation, and renewal.

Taken together, these dimensions present a complete framework for institutional life. For leaders, the lesson is unequivocal: authority must remain open to correction, and ego must yield to evaluation. The true test of leadership lies not in the decisiveness of action, but in the willingness to revisit that action when confronted with better judgment. For team members, the lesson is equally exacting: advice must be offered with honesty and courage, but once a direction is set, responsibility must be carried through with discipline and commitment.

The fall of Lanka is often attributed to external conflict, but its origins lie within. It is the combined effect of unheeded counsel, of decisions insulated from reflection, and of authority that ceased to listen. Kumbhkarana stands within this narrative not as a symbol of strength alone, but as a reminder of what institutions require to endure—leaders who are willing to listen, and individuals who are willing to both advise and align.

In contemporary organisations, where complexity demands both decisiveness and adaptability, this balance assumes even greater significance. Institutions do not lack intelligence or capability. What they often lack is the discipline to engage with counsel without defensiveness, and to execute decisions without fragmentation. Kumbhkarana's life therefore offers not a singular lesson, but a dual ethic—one that binds leadership and followership into a shared responsibility.

Institutions are sustained not by authority alone, nor by loyalty alone, but by the interplay between the two: the courage to speak, the humility to listen, and the discipline to act. When these come together, they contribute to the creation of conditions where leadership rises beyond position and takes the shape of principle.

Views expressed are personal

FOOD
SECURITY



TARUN SHRIDHAR
THE WRITER
IS DIRECTOR
GENERAL, ICFA,
AND FORMER
SECRETARY,
MINISTRY OF
FISHERIES, ANIMAL
HUSBANDRY AND
DAIRYING, GOI

From Hormuz to Kabul, war is weaponising supply chains—and food security is fast becoming the world's most contested strategic battleground

Wars That Starve the World

As conflicts choke energy, fertiliser and trade routes, the global food system faces renewed stress—testing India's resilience and its role as stabiliser

The spectre of war refuses to cease haunting the world and its food. Just when the scars inflicted by the COVID-19 pandemic on global food systems were beginning to heal, and the tremors of Russia's invasion of Ukraine were settling into an uneasy normalcy, fresh and even more menacing conflicts have erupted. The ongoing military operations by the United States and Israel against Iran, the closure of the Strait of Hormuz, the disruption of the Red Sea shipping lanes, and the open war between Pakistan and Afghanistan have collectively created a geopolitical maelstrom that threatens to unravel whatever stability the global food and agriculture sector had painstakingly rebuilt. For a country like India, which has emerged as a beacon of food security amidst global turmoil, the implications are both a challenge and an opportunity.

New Theatre of War and its Fallout on Food

The Russia-Ukraine war of 2022 has demonstrated how conflict in one part of the world can send food prices spiralling across continents. Russia and Ukraine together accounted for nearly 30 per cent of global wheat exports, 32 per cent of barley, and over 50 per cent of sunflower oil. The disruption of the Black Sea grain corridor sent shockwaves through vulnerable nations. India, after initially offering to step in, was compelled to impose an export ban in May 2022 due to a severe heatwave that ravaged domestic production forecasts.

Fast forward to 2026, and the lessons remain unlearned. The military confrontation between the US-Israel alliance and Iran has effectively choked the Strait of Hormuz—through which approximately 27 per cent of the world's oil exports, 20 per cent of global LNG, and one-third of traded urea fertiliser transit. Shipping through the Strait has declined sharply. Simultaneously, the Red Sea has turned hostile, with vessels rerouted around the Cape of Good Hope, adding time and cost. In effect, two critical maritime chokepoints have been rendered perilous.

Impact on India: Fertiliser, the Achilles Heel

For India, the most immediate consequence is the disruption of fertiliser supplies. Our agriculture's dependence on imports—approximately 90 per cent of phosphatic



Any disruption in energy or shipping routes directly hits fertiliser availability and cost

fertilisers and 100 per cent of potash—constitutes a structural vulnerability. India imports about 30 per cent of its fertiliser requirement, with West Asia accounting for a large share. Qatar, the UAE and Oman together supply nearly 76 per cent of India's sulphur imports, while Qatar, Saudi Arabia and Iran are key exporters of urea.

With LNG supply disruptions and rising costs, India's fertiliser sector faces a potential crisis ahead of the Kharif season. Global urea prices have already surged. If the blockade persists, the availability of urea, DAP and other inputs could be constrained, impacting sowing and food production. The fertiliser subsidy burden would rise further.

Pakistan-Afghanistan: A Humanitarian Catastrophe

The Pakistan-Afghanistan hostilities have closed borders and disrupted trade. For Afghanistan, already deeply food-insecure, this is catastrophic. Even before the conflict, 95 per cent of households reportedly lacked sufficient food. Now, with supply lines severed and aid declining, an estimated 17.4 million Afghans face severe food insecurity. The mass deportation of over 2.5 million Afghans has further strained resources. The World Food Programme has reported a sharp rise in malnutrition.

Pakistan itself is not immune. Wheat production is expected to decline, with key regions affected by conflict. The spectre of food shortages looms over an already fragile economy.

India has, in recent years, sent more than 60 million tonnes of wheat to Afghani-

stan through humanitarian channels. Our role as a responsible food provider has been acknowledged. The question now is whether regional instability will impede this engagement.

The Global Hunger Landscape

According to the World Food Programme's 2026 Global Outlook, 318 million people face acute hunger worldwide—more than double the pre-pandemic figure. Of these, 41 million are at Emergency levels or worse. Two simultaneous famines have been confirmed—in Gaza and parts of Sudan. Conflict drives 69 per cent of global hunger, while climate shocks compound the crisis.

The FAO Food Price Index reversed course in February 2026, rising to 125.3 points—driven by higher cereal and oil prices. Global wheat production is projected to decline. These are not abstract statistics; they translate into empty stomachs across the Global South.

India: The Bastion of Food Security

Against this backdrop, India's food and agriculture story stands out. Food grain production in 2024-25 touched a record 357.73 million tonnes. Four crops—rice, wheat, soybean and groundnut—registered record output. Rice reached 150.18 million tonnes, while wheat climbed to 117.94 million tonnes. Pulses and oilseeds also recorded growth.

The livestock sector continues its strong trajectory. Milk production stood at 248 million tonnes, with per capita availability well above the global average. Egg production

touched 149.11 billion, while fish production surged to 19.78 million tonnes. Total meat production stood at 10.5 million tonnes.

Agriculture contributes approximately 16 per cent of GDP and supports 46 per cent of the population. Growth over the last five years has been robust, driven by livestock and fisheries. The future of agricultural growth will increasingly be defined by these sectors.

Wheat Exports: A Full Circle

A notable development has been the Government's decision in February 2026 to lift the wheat export ban imposed in May 2022. India has permitted the export of 2.5 million tonnes of wheat, along with additional wheat products. This was enabled by record production and comfortable stock levels.

This is a confident step. Indian wheat re-entering the global market sends a signal of food security strength and addresses diaspora demand. One hopes volumes will increase as India strengthens its position in the global grain trade.

The Larger Picture: Lessons for Policy

The recurrence of war and disruption underscores the need for a strategically anticipatory food policy.

First, fertiliser vulnerability must be addressed. Dependence on imports exposes the sector to geopolitical risks. Diversification, buffer stocks, domestic production and alternative fertilisers must form the pillars of a new security architecture.

Second, disruption of trade routes reinforces the need to invest in food processing and value addition. A nation producing such vast quantities cannot afford large-scale wastage. Food processing must be treated as a core national priority.

Third, the global hunger crisis offers India an opportunity to position itself as a responsible food superpower. We have the production, surpluses and capability. What is needed is a coherent food diplomacy strategy.

Finally, the growing conflicts across the world make it clear that food is no longer merely an economic commodity. It is a strategic asset, a diplomatic tool, and a humanitarian obligation. India, with its resilient farm sector, must not squander this advantage. The world is hungry, and it is looking at us.

Views expressed are personal

PROCLAMATION REQUIRING THE APPEARANCE OF ACCUSED PERSON

See Section 82 Cr.P.C.

Whereas complaint has been made before me that the accused person Namely Nauhindh Diet Food Pvt Ltd & **Mr. A Mahapreet Singh S/o Harpreet Singh R/o**19, 3rd Floor, West Auehul, Road, West Punjabi Bagh, Delhi. has committed (or is suspected to have committed) the offence in **CC No. 2085/2021 U/s 138 NI Act PS: Shalimar Bagh, Delhi** and it has been returned to a warrant of arrest thereupon issued that the said accused **Mr. A Mahapreet Singh**, cannot be found and whereas it has been shown to my satisfaction that the said accused **Mr. A Mahapreet Singh**, has absconded (or is concealing himself to avoid the service of the said warrant).

Proclamation is hereby made that the said **Mr. A Mahapreet Singh**, accused of **CC No. 2085/2021 U/s 138 NI Act PS: Shalimar Bagh, Delhi** is required to appear before this Court to answer the said complaint on or before **30.05.2026**.

By Order
Ms. Ebbani Aggarwal
JMFC-03 Room No.107
Rohini Court Delhi

PROCLAMATION REQUIRING THE APPEARANCE OF ACCUSED PERSON

See Section 84 Bhartiya Nagarik Suraksha Sanhita, 2023

Whereas complaint has been made before me that accused person **Manbir Singh S/o** Badal Singh, R/o: C-63, OMI Crome Society, Greater Noida (U.P.), has committed (or is suspected to have committed) the offence in **FIR No. 290/2019, U/S 379/411 IPC, PS Welcome, North-East Distt., Delhi** and it has been returned to a warrant of arrest thereupon issued that the said accused **Manbir Singh** cannot be found, and whereas it has been shown to my satisfaction that the said accused **Manbir Singh** has absconded (or is concealing himself to avoid the service of the said warrant);

Proclamation is hereby made that **Manbir Singh** the said accused of **FIR No. 290/2019, U/S 379/411 IPC, PS Welcome, North-East Distt., Delhi**, is required to appear before this Court to answer the said complaint on or before **02.05.2026**.

By Order
Ms. Deepakshi Rana
Judicial Magistrate First Class-03
1st Floor, Shahdara Distt.,
Karkardooma Courts, Delhi

PROCLAMATION REQUIRING THE APPEARANCE OF ACCUSED PERSON

See Section 82 CrPC

Whereas complaint has been made before me that accused **Vineet Kumar S/o Ravinder R/o Desu Wali Gali, Mahipalpur, Delhi** has committed (or is suspected to have committed) the offence in case registered vide **FIR No. 186/2020 U/S 379/411/34 IPC, PS IGI Airport metro, Delhi** and it has been returned to a warrant of arrest their upon issued that the said accused **Vineet Kumar** cannot be found and whereas it hasbeen shown to my satisfaction that the said **Vineet Kumar** has absconded (or is concealing himself to avoid the servie of the said warrant).

Proclamation is hereby made that the said accused **Vineet Kumar of FIR No. 186/2020 U/S 379/411/34 IPC, PS IGI Airport metro, Delhi** is required to appear before this court (or before me) to answer the complaint on or before the day of **04.06.2026**.

By Order,
Sh. Pranav Joshi
Addl. Chief Judicial Magistrate-01
Court No. 02, Ground Floor, Main Building
Patiala House Courts, New Delhi

PROCLAMATION REQUIRING THE APPEARANCE OF ACCUSED PERSON

See Section 82 CrPC

Whereas complaint has been made before me that accused person **Sanafil Husain, R/o** HDB Financial Services D-8, Udyog Nagar, New Delhi-41, **Also at: (1) C-9/386, Sultanpuri, New Delhi, (2) Village Majrpatai Khalas, PS-Didoli JP Nagar, Amroha-244102**, has committed (or is suspected to have committed) the offence in **CC NI Act No. 5365/2019, U/S 138 NI Act, PS Moti Nagar, West Distt., Delhi** and it has been returned to a warrant of arrest thereupon issued that the said accused **Sanafil Husain** cannot be found, and whereas it has been shown to my satisfaction that the said accused **Sanafil Husain** has absconded (or is concealing himself to avoid the service of the said warrant);

Proclamation is hereby made that **Sanafil Husain** the said accused of **CC NI Act No. 5365/2019, U/S 138 NI Act, PS Moti Nagar, West Distt., Delhi**, is required to appear before this Court to answer the said complaint on or before **08.05.2026**.

By Order
Ms. Poonam Singh
Judicial Magistrate First Class (NI Act)-04,
West Distt., Room No. 04, Annex-I,
Tis Hazari Courts, Delhi

PROCLAMATION REQUIRING THE APPEARANCE OF A PERSON ACCUSED

See Section 82 Cr. P.C. / 84 BNSS

Whereas complaint has been made before me that accused person **Karan Gupta S/o** Birju Gupta R/o **H. No.277, Block 9, Dakshinpuri, Delhi** has Committed (or is suspected to have committed) the offence in case **FIR No.338/2015 U/s 12 D.V. Act, P.S. Kalyanpuri, Delhi** and it has been returned to a warrant of arrest thereupon issued that the said accused **Karan Gupta** cannot be found and whereas it has been shown to my satisfaction that the said accused **Karan Gupta** has absconded (or is concealing himself to avoid the service of the said warrant).
Proclamation is hereby made that the said accused **Karan Gupta** of case **FIR No.338/2015 U/s 12 D.V. Act, P.S. Kalyanpuri, Delhi** is required to appear before this Court to answer the said complaint on or before **12.05.2026**.

By Order
Ms. Ritika Kansal
Judicial Magistrate First Class (Mahila Court)-02
Court No. 24
Karkardooma Courts, Delhi

NORTH CENTRAL RAILWAY

E-TENDER NOTICE

Divisional Railway Manager (Works) N.C. Railway, Jhansi for and behalf of President of India invites sealed "Open Tender" through on Line (E-Tendering) for the following work.

E-Tender No.: JHS-ENGG-N-2026-58
Description of work : Improvement of road surface for proper drainage on LHS No. 429, 442, 444, 445 under ADEN/GWL sub- division.
Approx Cost : 12527489.25 Earnest Money : 430500.00
Date of closing Tender : 22/04/2026 at 15:00 hrs.
Date of completion/period from issue acceptance letter : 06 Months

E-Tender No.: JHS-ENGG-N-2026-59
Description of work : Virangana Lakshmbai Jhansi - Gwalior - TBSR (H-Beam) - 1677
Approx Cost : 60800560.64 Earnest Money : 1216000.00
Date of closing Tender : 22/04/2026 at 15:00 hrs.

Date of completion/period from issue acceptance letter : 09 Months
• Tender online can be submitted upto 15:00 hrs on 22.04.2026
• For full details and submission of bid please see the Indian Railways website www.ireps.gov.in 701/26 (AS)
North central railways www.ncr.indianrailways.gov.in @ CPRONCR

NORTH CENTRAL RAILWAY

E-TENDERING TENDER NOTICE

Divisional Railway Manager (Works) N.C. Railway, Jhansi for and behalf of President of India invites sealed "Open Tender" through on Line (E-Tendering) for the following work.

E-Tender No.	Approx Cost	Earnest Money
JHS-ENGG-N-2026-62	10558660.20	211200.00

Description of work: Pre and post tamping track measurement survey using Trimble GEDO Vorsors trolley system in VGLJ-DHO section of ADEN/LINE/JHS & ADEN/GWL under Sr. DEN/N/JHS jurisdiction in Jhansi Division.

Date of closing Tender: 16.04.2026 at 15:00 hrs.

Date of completion/period from issue acceptance letter : 08 Months

• Tender online can be submitted upto 15:00 hrs on 16.04.2026. • For full details and submission of bid please see the Indian Railways website www.ireps.gov.in 692/26 (ADM)

North central railways www.ncr.indianrailways.gov.in @ CPRONCR

UJVN Limited

H.O.: "UJJAWAL", Maharani Bagh, G.M.S. Road, Dehradun-248006
Telephones: 0135-2763808, Fax: 0135- 2763508
CIN No. U40101UR2001SGC025866, Website : www.ujvn.com

RO No. 263 Tender Notice Dated : 31/03/2026

Office of the Executive Engineer (E&M KG-I&KG-II SHP), UJVN Ltd., GuptaKashi, invites sealed tenders from interested parties. Brief summary of tender is given below:

Tender No: 01/EE(E&MKG-I&KG-II SHP)/KG-II/2026-27: "Supply & replacement of hydraulic operated slide valve of Unit-I with pipeline in bypass system and S&F of MIV seals in Unit-I & II at Kaliganga-II SHP (2x2.25 MW+15% COL) located in Tehsil Ukhimath, District-Rudraprayag"

Estimated cost: ₹ 14,50,000/-, GST extra.

Date of availability of bid document on website: 01.04.2026, 17:00 hrs.

Last date for submission of tender : 27.04.2026 upto 11:00 hrs

For fuller & further details, kindly visit our website. The tender documents can be downloaded from the Nigam's website "www.ujvn.com"

Executive Engineer (E&M KG-I & KG-II SHP)

"Avoid wasteful use of Electricity"

NORTH CENTRAL RAILWAY

E-Tender Notice No.: Sr. DEE/RS/ELS/CNB/2025-26/ET-19 & ET-20
Dated : 28.03.2026

E-TENDER NOTICE

Senior Divisional Electrical Engineer/RS/N. C. Rly./Kanpur. for and on behalf of the President of India, invite the following Open Tender for the following work up to Tender Opening Date & Time. The details of the tenders are as under--

Tender No.: ELS-CNB-2025-26-ET-19

Name of work : Repair/Reconditioning of 7775 KVA transformer for three phase electric locomotive of ELS/CNB.

Approximate Value (In Rs.) : 1,00,84,482.66 (Rs. One Crore Eighty-Four Thousand Four Hundred Eighty Two and Sixty-Six Paise only.), Bid Security (In Rs.) : 2,01,700.00 (Rs. Two Lakh One Thousand Seven Hundred Only). Completion period of Work : 12 Months, Tender Document Cost (In Rs.) : NIL, Tender Opening Date & Time : 21.04.2026 & 15:30 hrs.

Tender No.: ELS-CNB-2025-26-ET-20

Name of work : Repair/Reconditioning of 6531 KVA transformer for three phase electric locomotive of ELS/CNB.

Approximate Value (In Rs.) : 2,15,38,683.85 (Rs. Two Crore Fifteen Lakh Thirty Eight Thousand Six Hundred Eighty Three and Eighty Five Paise only.), Bid Security (In Rs.) : 4,30,800.00 (Rs. Four Lakh Thirty Thousand Eight Hundred Only), Completion period of Work : 24 Months, Tender Document Cost (In Rs.) : NIL, Tender Opening Date & Time : 21.04.2026 & 15:30 hrs.

Note – 1. The complete information along with tender document of above e-Tenders is available on website www.ireps.gov.in up to due date & time of tender opening. 2. Bids, other than in the form of E-Bids, shall not be accepted against above Tenders. For this purpose, venders are required to get themselves registered with IREPS website along with Digital Signature Certificates issued by CCA under IT Act-2000. 3. Offer rates quoted in the form of e-tender schedule & duly signed digitally shall be final. No other documents related to offer rates shall be entertained. Tenderers are advised not to attach any document related to offer rates (except undertaking(s) asked). These documents shall be treated as NULL and void and shall not be considered for evaluation of offer. 4. Documents being attached should be signed by the tenderer on its body. 5. This tender notice has also been uploaded on www.ncr.indianrailways.gov.in. 6. In case of any difficulty helpline available on the website of IREPS may be approached. 698/26 (D)

North central railways @ CPRONCR www.ncr.indianrailways.gov.in

NORTH CENTRAL RAILWAY

E-Procurement Tender Notice No. 09/2026 Dated : 27.03.2026

E-Procurement Tender Notice

On behalf of President of India, Sr. Divisional Materials Manager, North Central Railway, Prayagraj invites the E-procurement tenders:

Tender No. : 19256354 Qty. : 124 Set.

Description : Supply, Installation and Commissioning of Electrically Operated Wind Screen Wiper.

EMD (Rs.) : 7,73,760/- Tender Opening Date : 21.04.2026

Tender No. : 19257633A Qty. : 92 Nos.

Description : Supply, Installation & Testing of Waterless Urinals.

EMD (Rs.) : 4,47,270/- Tender Opening Date : 21.04.2026

Note : (1) The complete information of above E-Procurement Tender is available on IREPS website i.e. <https://www.ireps.gov.in> (2) Bids other than in the form of E-Bids shall not be accepted against Above Tender, for this purpose, Vendors are required to get themselves registered with IREPS website along with Class III Digital Signature certificates issued by CCA under IT Act-2000. (3) Rates entered into financial rate page and duly signed digitally shall be considered. Rates and any other financial entity in any other form/letter head if attached by vendor shall be straight away ignored and shall not be considered. (4) Documents being attached should be signed on their body. The above tender notice has been uploaded on <http://www.ncr.indianrailways.gov.in> in case of any difficulty helpline available on the IREPS website may be approached. 697/26 (C)

North central railways www.ncr.indianrailways.gov.in @ CPRONCR

NORTH CENTRAL RAILWAY

Tender Notice No.- 12320252026 Date- 25.03.2026

E-TENDERING TENDER NOTICE

Divisional Railway Manager (Engineering)/North Central Railway/ Prayagraj, for and on behalf of the President of India, invites E-TENDERS on prescribed form for the following work to 13.30 hrs. on 22.04.2026. The details of the Tender are as under:

S.N.1. Tender No: 274 Name of work Construction of Yard Drain in Aligarh Junction Station yard under ADEN/ALJN

Approx Cost of work: ₹ 22966031.04 Earnest Money: ₹ 459400.00

Date of opening of tender: 22.04.2026 Completion Period: 12 months

Eligibility Criteria for similar work: Any Civil engineering work

Note: 1. E-Tender Forms shall be issued free of cost to all tenderers. 2. The complete information along with tender document of above E-TENDER is available on Website www.ireps.gov.in up to 13.30 hrs on the due date of tender opening i.e. 22.04.2026. 3. Bids other than in the form of E-Bids shall not be accepted against above tenders. For this purpose, vendors are required to get themselves registered with IREPS website along with Digital Signature Certificate issued by CCA under IT Act-2000. 4. The tenderers shall submit a copy of certificate as given in tender document in standard format without which their tender may not be considered and shall be summarily rejected. 5. In case of any difficulty helpline available on the website of IREPS may be approached. 6. The tenderer has to submit necessary documents in compliance of clause 10 to 18 (Part-I) of GCC April '2022 mandatorily, otherwise offer will be considered as incomplete offer and accordingly shall not be considered. 691/26 FA

North central railways @ CPRONCR www.ncr.indianrailways.gov.in

NORTH CENTRAL RAILWAY

Open Tender No.- JHS-RCNK-M-BOG-25-26-49

E-TENDER NOTICE

E-tenders are invited from experienced and interested contractors by Chief Workshop Manager, Rail Coach Naveenikaran Karkhana Jhansi on behalf of the President of India for the under mentioned work -

Name of Work : "Overhauling of rolling stock Bogies & CBC along with Lifting/Lowering of Coaches during SS-I/II/III schedule"

Cost of work : Rs. 8,03,65,903.90 /- (Including 18% GST)

Bid Security : Rs. 16,07,300.00/- Time of completion : Twenty-Four Months

Online Tender Closing Date & Time : 23.04.2026 at 11:00 Hrs.

Detailed information about tender and tender format is available at website www.ireps.gov.in 693/26 (AS)

North central railways www.ncr.indianrailways.gov.in @ CPRONCR

THE LAW IS SET TO TAKE EFFECT IN 30 DAYS

Horror, fear in West Bank

Israel okays hanging Palestinians convicted of murdering Israelis

JERUSALEM: Hundreds of protesters took to the streets across the embattled Palestinian territories on Tuesday in outrage after Israel's parliament passed a measure establishing the death penalty by hanging for Palestinians convicted of murdering Israelis.

Palestinians, young and old, held sit-ins and marches in the Israeli-occupied West Bank, the territory where the new law is most sweeping. It orders West Bank military courts — which try only Palestinians — to make the death penalty the default sentence for those convicted, except in special circumstances.

"Time is running out, and silence is deadly," read the signs carried by protesters in the central West Bank city of Nablus, which showed an animation of a prisoner wearing the Palestinian keffiyeh scarf next to a noose. "Stop the law from executing prisoners, before it's too late."

The bill passed its final vote in the Israeli parliament late Monday, to cheers and applause. Israel's firebrand minister of national security, Itamar Ben-Gvir, who spear-headed the push for the legislation, described the law as long overdue and a sign of strength and national pride.

The law is set to take effect in 30 days, but its implementa-



Key Points

» Palestinians held sit-ins and marches in West Bank

» The bill passed its final vote in Israeli parliament

» The Palestinian Foreign Ministry called for sanctions on Israel's parliament and its suspension from international bodies

A woman along with others carries the body of her son who, according to the Palestinian Ministry of Health, was killed in an Israeli army raid in West Bank

AP/PTI

tion could be delayed by pending court proceedings at Israel's highest tribunal.

The measure is not retroactive and won't apply to current prisoners.

Still, it signalled an extreme hardening of Israeli penal policy that elicited fear from the protesters for all Palestinian prisoners in Israeli jails — emblems of national resistance.

"You are the symbol of struggle. You are the symbol of steadfastness,"

the protesters in Nablus chanted, some holding up signs with the faces of friends and family currently in Israeli prisons.

The Fatah political party announced a general strike in the northern part of the West Bank for Wednesday.

Palestinian officials released statements saying the death penalty measure violated international law and asking other countries to intervene.

The Palestinian Foreign

Ministry called for sanctions on Israel's parliament and its suspension from international bodies.

"The law represents a critical turning point in the formalisation of extrajudicial killings under a legal guise," the statement said.

"The Ministry stresses that this law, in its essence, constitutes an institutionalised policy of field executions based on discriminatory and racist standards."

AGENCIES

Indian-origin man shot dead in Canada

OTTAWA: A man, known to be of Indian origin, has been killed in Canada's Surrey in an incident of shooting allegedly related to organised crime, local media reported.

The shooting incident was reported from a townhouse complex in Surrey's Sullivan Heights on Saturday night, in which a man was shot dead, Global News reported.

The IHIT said in an update on Monday that the victim has been identified as 27-year-old Jasman Sekhon.

AGENCIES

Japan deploys its first long-range missiles

TOKYO: Japan's first long-range missile was deployed at a southwestern army camp, officials said Tuesday, as the country pushes to bolster its offensive capabilities.

The upgraded Type-12 land-to-ship missiles, developed and produced by Japan's Mitsubishi Heavy Industries, became operational at Camp Kengun in Kumamoto prefecture. "As Japan faces the most severe and complex security environment in the postwar era ... it is an extremely important capability to strengthen Japan's deterrence and responsiveness," Defense Minister Shinjiro Koizumi told reporters. "It demonstrates Japan's firm determination and capability to defend itself."



REPRESENTATIONAL IMAGE

The upgraded Type-12 missile has a range of about 1,000 kilometers (620 miles), a significant extension from the 200-kilometer (125-mile) range of the original that would allow it to reach main-

land China.

The deployment of the long-range missile gives Japan a "standoff" capability, meaning it can strike enemy missile bases from afar, marking a break from the self-defense-

only policy the country long followed under its pacifist constitution. Residents opposing the deployment near the residential area staged protests outside the Kengun camp, saying it would escalate tension and increases risks the area could be targeted by potential enemies.

Also Tuesday, a hyper-sonic glide vehicle, a new weapons system designed for island defense, was deployed to Camp Fuji in the Shizuoka prefecture, west of Tokyo. Additional deployment of the upgraded Type-12 missiles and HGVs at other locations in Japan, including Hokkaido in the north and Miyazaki in the south, are planned by March 2028.

AGENCIES

China, Pakistan propose peace plan for West Asia

Call for 'immediate' end to hostilities

BEIJING: China and Pakistan on Tuesday put forward a five-point peace proposal to end the West Asia war, including a call for safe passage of ships through the Strait of Hormuz.

The peace proposal was put forward after Chinese Foreign Minister Wang Yi held talks on the Iran situation with visiting Pakistani Deputy Prime Minister and Foreign Minister Ishaq Dar. Dar arrived here to brief Wang about his recent talks with the foreign ministers of Turkey, Egypt and Saudi Arabia to promote talks between the US and Iran to end the ongoing conflict.

After Dar-Wang talks, the two countries put forward five proposals on restoring peace and stability in the Gulf region and West Asia, as well as safe passage through the Strait. The proposals included the immediate cessation of hostilities, initiation of

peace talks as soon as possible, ensuring the safety of non-military targets and safety of navigation, and safeguarding the primacy of the UN Charter. The Strait of Hormuz, together with its adjacent waters, is an important global shipping route for goods and energy, a joint statement issued after their talks said.

"China and Pakistan call on the parties to protect the security of ships and crew members stranded in the Strait of Hormuz, allow the early and safe passage of civilian and commercial ships, and restore normal passage through the Strait as soon as possible," Pakistani media reported, quoting the joint statement.

Earlier, China said three of its ships carrying oil supplies had passed through the Strait of Hormuz and thanked relevant parties for facilitation and coordination.

AGENCIES

World Briefs

PAKISTAN: 9 MILITANTS KILLED AFTER ATTACK ON SCHOOL IN NORTHWEST

PESHAWAR: At least nine militants were killed in an operation by Pakistan's security forces after an attack on a government school in northwestern Khyber Pakhtunkhwa province, police said on Tuesday. The militants stormed Government High School Khwaja Mir Kalay in the Aka Khel area of Bara Tehsil, Khyber district, on Monday, in an apparent attempt to seize control of the building. During the attack, the militants removed the national flag and hoisted their own flag on the school building. Security forces responded swiftly, engaging the militants in a fierce gun battle.

SENEGAL'S PRESIDENT SIGNS HARSHER ANTI-GAY PENALTIES INTO LAW

DAKAR: Senegal's President Bassirou Diomaye Faye has signed into law a new provision increasing the punishment for homosexuality in the largely Muslim West African nation, the latest African country to impose harsher penalties against the LGBTQ+ community. The law was passed by parliament last month with near-unanimous support. It doubles the punishment for those convicted from prison sentences of one to five years to between five and 10 years.

PUSH FOR PNG TO CUT LPG DEPENDENCE

Govt rolls out time-bound framework for nationwide gas pipeline expansion

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: Amidst the month-long unrest in West Asia, the Centre has set a time-bound framework for pipeline infrastructure expansion nationwide in an effort to reduce the demand for LPG.

The Natural Gas and Petroleum Products Distribution (Through Laying, Building, Operation and Expansion of Pipelines and Other Facilities) Order, 2026 under the Essential Commodities Act, 1955 was announced by the government on Tuesday in an official communication.

The order introduces a streamlined and time-bound framework for the nationwide expansion of pipeline infrastructure - provision of PNG connections and enabling a gradual transition from LPG to piped gas in areas where infrastructure is available.

The order authorized entities to lay and expand pipelines across regions to facilitate the rapid expansion of City Gas Distribution (CGD) networks



People wait with empty LPG cylinders at a gas agency to avail the refilled ones amid the ongoing supply crunch, in Navi Mumbai

HIGHLIGHTS

- » The govt issued an order, introducing a streamlined and time-bound framework for the nationwide expansion
- » The order authorised entities to lay and expand pipelines across regions to facilitate the rapid expansion of City Gas Distribution networks

and improve last-mile connectivity for piped natural gas (PNG). The government claims that by streamlining compliance standards, doing away with arbitrary levies, and adopting precisely defined compensation procedures like “dig and restore” and “dig and pay” to reduce conflicts, the Order creates an open and investor-friendly regulatory system. Additionally, it balances the requirements of infrastructure development

with the public interest by incorporating safeguards such as a dispute resolution process and rules to prevent unjustified denial of access by private entities or municipal authorities.

The government is promoting natural gas as a crucial transition fuel at a time when the world's energy environment is changing and energy demand is rising. According to officials, the Order aims to guarantee fair access to cleaner energy, expedite infrastructure devel-

opment, and make conducting business easier.

By diversifying the gas distribution network and increasing investor confidence through regulatory clarity and quicker approvals, the government anticipates that the reform would improve energy security. Additionally, it will probably speed up the development of pipeline infrastructure in urban and semi-urban regions, enhance air quality by encouraging the use of cleaner

fuels, and promote economic growth by guaranteeing a steady and reasonably priced energy supply.

Regularly, the Ministry of Petroleum and Natural Gas along with other important ministries - Shipping and Ports, and External Affairs - are holding briefings here in the national capital. The centre further underlined that all refineries are operating at high capacity and adequate crude inventories are available, while sufficient stocks of petrol and diesel are being maintained. In another major move towards boosting the domestic LPG production from refineries, the Indian OMCs, reportedly, maximising output by diverting propane/butane from petrochemicals into the domestic cooking pool.

The government said retail fuel outlets are functioning normally across the country, although panic buying was reported in some areas due to rumours, leading to unusually high sales and crowding at petrol pumps.

MPOST BUREAU

NEW DELHI: India's first Iranian crude oil cargo since 2019 may be headed towards a port in Gujarat, according to ship tracking data.

Indian refiners have been looking to purchase a few cargoes of Iranian oil on water following the recent sanctions waiver by Washington.

“The Indo-Iranian oil trade has flickered back to life. Following the US administration's decision to grant a 30-day window for Iranian oil “on the water” due to regional conflict, the vessel Ping Shun is now en route to Vadinar (in Gujarat) with 600,000 barrels of crude. This is the first such delivery since May 2019 and comes at a critical time for Indian refiners facing tightening inventories,” said Sumit Ritolia, Lead Research Analyst, Refining and Modelling at commodity market analytic firm Kpler.

While the identity of the buyer is unknown, Vadinar is home for 20 million tonnes a year oil refinery of Russian oil giant Rosneft-backed Naraya Energy. It also is the landing point for crude oil that goes to hinterland refineries such as

INSIGHT

- » While the identity of the buyer is unknown, Vadinar is home for 20 million tonnes a year oil refinery of Russian oil giant Rosneft-backed Naraya Energy
- » It also is the landing point for crude oil that goes to hinterland refineries such as Bina refinery of BPCL

Bina refinery of Bharat Petroleum Corporation Ltd (BPCL).

India's oil ministry has so far maintained that techno-commercial feasibility will drive the decision on resuming buying Iranian crude.

Historically, India was a major buyer of Iranian crude, importing significant volumes of Iranian light and heavy grades due to strong refinery compatibility and favourable commercial terms.

Following sanctions tightening in 2018, imports ceased from May 2019, with volumes replaced by Middle Eastern, US and other grades. At peak, Iranian crude accounted for 11.5

per cent of India's total imports. India used to buy 518,000 barrels per day of Iranian oil in 2018, which slowed to 268,000 bpd between January and May 2019 when the US granted waivers to a few buyers. There have been no imports since.

The key grades that Indian refiners used to purchase are Iran light and Iran heavy crudes. “The Aframax Ping Shun (IMO 9231901) loaded with Iranian crude oil from Kharg Island in early March has emerged as the first vessel observed signalling a destination of Vadinar, India since May 2019, following sanction reimposition on Iranian oil by the first Trump administration,” Ritolia said.

The US earlier this month waived sanctions on the purchase of Iranian oil at sea for 30 days in its latest attempt to ease oil prices that have been driven up by the US-Israeli war on Iran.

That window expires April 19. An estimated 95 million barrels of Iranian oil is on vessels on sea, of which around 51 million barrels could be sold to India while the remaining are better suited for buyers in China and Southeast Asia.

Oracle lays off around 12K employees in India

Another round likely within a month

MPOST BUREAU

NEW DELHI: US-based IT firm Oracle is believed to have laid off approximately 12,000 staff in India, with another round of layoffs expected within a month, impacted employees said on Tuesday.

Globally, the company has fired around 30,000 employees. “In India, around 12,000 employees have been laid off. The company is planning another mass layoff within a month,” said two people impacted by the retrenchment, including one from the company's human resource department.

The company has approximately 30,000 employees in India, including those affected by the layoffs.

Oracle declined to comment on the development.

Oracle, in an email sent to staff, said the employees were informed about certain organisational changes and “because of these changes, a decision has been taken to streamline the operations, and as a result, unfortunately, the position you currently hold will become redundant.”

The company has offered 15 days' salary to each employee who has completed a year of service in India, in addition to one month of unpaid wages till termination date, leave encashment, gratuity based on eligibility and pay for a one-month notice period.



TAKEAWAYS

- » Globally, the company has fired around 30,000 employees
- » The company has approximately 30,000 employees in India, including those affected by the layoffs

Oracle has also offered a two-month salary as a top-up.

However, the severance package is available for those who voluntarily and amicably resign from the company.

An ex-employee of Oracle, Merugu Sridhar, said that he was laid off in September for protesting against the 16-hour work shift that the company has in India.

“I contacted my friends and those who are in human resources. They shared that most of the Indians working in the US with the company have been impacted because the local laws there are very strict when it comes to the retrenchment of their citizens,” Sridhar said.

I-T dept signs ‘record’ 219 APAs in FY26

MPOST BUREAU

NEW DELHI: The Income Tax Department has signed a record 219 advance pricing agreements (APA) in the current fiscal year ending March 31. With this the total APAs signed so far stood at 1,034.

“CBDT signs a record 219 Advance Pricing Agreements in FY 2025-26, the highest ever in a single FY, crossing the record of 174 APAs signed last year,” the I-T department said in a post on X.

The success of the APA programme has significantly contributed to ease of doing business, particularly for multinational enterprises engaged in cross-border transactions, it added.

Government cancels auction of 11 critical & strategic mineral blocks

MPOST BUREAU

NEW DELHI: The government has cancelled the auction of 11 critical and strategic mineral blocks which were put on sale in the sixth round on account of poor investor response and lack of qualified bidders.

The development comes as a setback to the government's efforts to ramp up domestic exploration and production of critical minerals amid global supply chain disruptions.

In an annulment notice, the mines ministry said that the auction process for 5 mineral blocks was cancelled since no bids were received.

The notice further said the auction process of five other mineral blocks was annulled

as there were less than three technically-qualified bidders.

Besides, auction process for Beku Rare Metal Block, West Bengal was also annulled.

The mines ministry had in September last year launched the sixth tranche of auction for 23 critical mineral blocks spread across 13 states.

The auction included 19 composite licence (CL) blocks and four mining lease (ML) blocks in Andhra Pradesh, Chhattisgarh, Jharkhand, Karnataka, Maharashtra, Odisha, Rajasthan, Telangana, and West Bengal.

The blocks contain strategic minerals including lithium, cobalt, rare earth elements, niobium, tantalum, and vanadium.

So far, six rounds of auctions have been completed,

with 46 critical and strategic mineral blocks already sold, according to the mines ministry.

Critical minerals are pivotal for the country's economic development and mineral security. The global transition towards clean energy and advanced technologies has significantly increased the demand for minerals such as lithium, graphite, rare earth elements (REE), tungsten, vanadium, titanium and other rare metals.

Their limited availability and geographical concentration pose challenges to resilient supply chains worldwide.

The government has cancelled the auction of many critical minerals in the previous rounds of auction.

‘Highest since 2022’: Gas prices eclipse USD 4 per gallon in US

NEW YORK: US gas prices jumped past an average of USD 4 a gallon for the first time since 2022 on Tuesday, as the Iran war pushes fuel prices to soar worldwide.

According to the motor club AAA, the national average for a gallon of regular gasoline is now USD 4.02 — over a dollar more expensive than before the war began. The last time US drivers were collectively paying this much at the pump was nearly four years ago, following Russia's invasion of Ukraine.

The price is a national average, meaning drivers in some states have been paying

well over USD 4 a gallon for a while now. Prices vary from state to state due to factors ranging from nearby supply to differing tax rates.

Since the US and Israel launched the joint war against Iran on Feb. 28, the cost of crude oil — the main ingredient in gasoline — has spiked and swung rapidly. That's because the conflict has caused deep supply chain disruptions and cuts from major oil producers across the Middle East. Both Brent crude, the international standard, and benchmark US crude are now going for more than USD 100 per barrel — up

from roughly USD 70 before the war. Motorists around the world are also coping with higher gas prices. In Paris, for example, gas is at 2.34 euros per litre (USD 2.68), which is about USD 10.27 a gallon.

Higher gas prices are impacting consumers and businesses as many households continue to face wider cost-of-living strains. And as drivers pay more to cover necessities like gas or even utility bills impacted by soaring fuel costs, many may be forced to cut their budgets in other places.

“Americans (are) spending hundreds of millions of dol-

lars more on gasoline every day,” said Patrick De Haan, the head of petroleum analysis at fuel-tracking service GasBuddy. That, he said, has a negative impact on the “psyche of the US consumer,” which carries consequences for the economy overall.

Before launching the war, President Donald Trump bragged about keeping gas prices low. Consumer prices and the cost of living have already become flashpoints in this mid-term election year, with Democrats hammering Trump and Republicans as the GOP tries to hold majorities on Capitol Hill.

A recent AP-NORC poll found that 45 per cent of US adults are “extremely” or “very” concerned about being able to afford gas in the next few months, up from 30 per cent shortly after Trump won the 2024 presidential election with promises to lower costs.

Beyond visits to the pump, analysts point to groceries, which have to be restocked frequently and could also see price hikes as businesses' transportation and packaging costs pile up. Hauling other cargo and packages has also been impacted. The United Postal Service, for example, is seeking a tempo-

rary 8 per cent added charge on some of its popular products, including Priority Mail.

US diesel prices — the fuel used for many freight and delivery trucks — are now going for an average of USD 5.45 a gallon, up from about USD 3.76 a gallon before the war began, per AAA.

“It's going to mean more expensive bills for truckers, tractors and trains that move the US economy with diesel fuel. It's going to mean consumers are likely greeted by rising grocery prices — and broadly speaking, a rise in US inflation,” said De Haan. AGENCIES

CCTV cos to sell only made in India products from today

MPOST BUREAU

NEW DELHI: India's CCTV market will only sell made-in-India products, as the government has barred the sale of non-certified imported units from April 1, a senior official said on Tuesday.

The Ministry of Electronics and IT had barred the sale of CCTV units without Standardisation Testing and Quality Certification (STQC) from April 9, 2025, onwards, but allowed traders to exhaust imported inventories by March 31, 2026.

“The order to bar non-certified STQC was effective from April 9 onwards. The order does not impact any manufacturer in India,” the government official, who did not wish to be named, said.

CCTV traders said that the move has impacted Chinese CCTV companies like Hikvision and TP-Link.

They said STQC has not certified CCTV products of any Chinese company.

EASE OF DOING BUSINESS
CBIC operationalises reforms for e-comm exports & courier trade

NEW DELHI: The Central Board of Indirect Taxes and Customs (CBIC) has operationalised a set of comprehensive reforms to strengthen and streamline e-commerce exports and broader courier-based imports and exports, with effect from April 1.

These reforms include the complete removal of the Rs 10 lakh value cap per consignment on courier exports, the introduction of a streamlined framework for handling returned and rejected parcels and a legally backed Return to Origin (RTO) mechanism for unclear shipments, aimed at enhancing ease of doing business, the finance ministry said in a statement on Tuesday.

It will also reduce logistics inefficiencies and strengthen India's global export competitiveness, particularly for MSMEs, artisans and start-ups, it added.

As part of these reforms, it said, the existing value limit of Rs 10 lakh for commercial export consignments through courier mode has been removed.

“It will also reduce logistics inefficiencies and strengthen India's global export competitiveness, particularly for MSMEs, artisans and start-ups”

This measure is expected to significantly boost exports, especially for e-commerce exporters, by allowing greater flexibility in shipment value and enabling seamless exports through the courier mode, eliminating the need to divert such shipments to conventional air or sea cargo solely due to value restrictions, it said.

These initiatives were announced in the Budget presented in Parliament last month.

In order to address congestion and delays in the disposal of uncleared or unclaimed imported goods at Interna-

tional Courier Terminals, CBIC has introduced a Return to Origin (RTO) facility.

Under this facility, goods that remain uncleared or unclaimed for more than 15 days and are not prohibited, restricted or under enforcement hold may be returned to the origin following a simplified procedure, it said, adding, this is expected to ease congestion at courier terminals and improve logistics efficiency.

CBIC has also simplified the procedure for the re-import of returned or rejected goods, including those relating to e-commerce exports.

A risk-based approach has been adopted in place of consignment-wise verification, and necessary amendments have been carried out in the relevant notification.

In addition, it said, a dedicated return module has been developed in the Express Cargo Clearance System to facilitate smooth processing of such returns. These reforms are supported by system-based enhancements and process simplifications. MPOST

MPOST BUREAU

NEW DELHI: India's real GDP growth for the next fiscal could erode by around 1 percentage point, while retail inflation could rise by about 1.5 percentage points from their baseline estimates if the Middle East conflict persists through the next fiscal, an EY report said.

The EY Economy Watch report said that several sectors, including employment-intensive sectors like textiles, paints, chemicals, fertilizers, cement and tires, could be directly impacted. Any reduction in employment or incomes in these sectors may further dampen aggregate demand. As a result, both supply and demand conditions may be adversely affected by global oil market disturbances.

It said the Indian economy, which imports nearly 90 per cent of its crude oil requirements, is also highly dependent on imports of natural gas and fertilizers, and is particularly vulnerable to such exter-



CLOSER LOOK

- » The EY report said that several sectors, including employment-intensive sectors like textiles, paints, chemicals, fertilizers, & cement, could be directly impacted
- » Any reduction in employment or incomes in these sectors may further dampen aggregate demand

nal shocks, with the adverse effects likely to cascade across multiple sectors through strong forward and backward linkages with crude oil and energy.

The ongoing conflict in the Middle East has significantly disrupted global crude oil and energy markets by affecting supply, storage, transportation and prices. Even if the conflict is resolved in the near term, some of these disruptions may take considerable time to normalise, it said.

“If the impact persists throughout FY27, we estimate that India's real GDP growth could erode by around 1 percentage points, while CPI

inflation could rise by approximately 1.5 percentage points from their baseline estimates of 7 per cent and 4 per cent respectively,” the EY Economy Watch report said.

EY in its February report had projected India's GDP could be between 6.8 and 7.2 per cent in the 2026-27 fiscal.

In response, the Government of India may need to deploy a substantive countercyclical policy. It may also be prudent for the GoI to co-opt larger and more industrialised states into this countercyclical effort. Additional provisions may be made to augment the Economic Stabilization Fund

(ESF) introduced by the GoI in FY26, EY said.

The government has already set up a Rs 1-lakh crore ESF to act as a financial buffer against global headwinds.

Global crude prices have risen by almost 50 per cent since the United States and Israel launched military strikes against Iran on February 28, triggering sweeping retaliation from Tehran. The Organisation for Economic Cooperation and Development (OECD) had last week projected India's GDP growth to moderate to 6.1 per cent in the next fiscal, from 7.6 per cent in the current financial year.

STRATEGIC PUSH TO COUNTER GLOBAL DISRUPTIONS

PM says India strengthening its role as ‘reliable’ semiconductor supplier

OUR CORRESPONDENT

SANAND (GUJARAT): Prime Minister Narendra Modi on Tuesday said the 21st Century has brought several challenges and global supply chains have been affected due to conflicts, emphasising that the government is laying a strong foundation for technology and energy security in the coming decades.

Modi inaugurated **Keynes Semicon's** outsourced semiconductor plant in Sanand, marking the commencement of production, and said India is strengthening its role as a reliable semiconductor supplier in the global market. In a sense, a new bridge has emerged today between Sanand and Silicon Valley, he said.

Addressing a gathering on the occasion, Modi said India is actively building a robust semiconductor ecosystem and simultaneously making



PM Narendra Modi walks through the Keynes facility during the inauguration of Keynes Semicon's OSAT facility at Sanand

PTI

significant efforts to establish a resilient supply chain for raw materials.

Modi noted that when the Coronavirus pandemic disrupted supply chains, India had decided to become a hub of semiconductor manufacturing.

"India is actively building a robust semiconductor eco-

system and simultaneously making significant efforts to establish a resilient supply chain for raw materials. India's participation in Pax Silica is a testament to this very endeavour. Working in tandem with our global partners, we aim to ensure a secure supply chain," Modi added.

HIGHLIGHTS

- » In Sanand, PM Modi inaugurated **Keynes Semicon's** outsourced semiconductor plant
- » He said India is actively building a robust semiconductor ecosystem
- » 'India had decided to become a hub of semiconductor manufacturing when the Coronavirus pandemic disrupted supply chains'

National Critical Minerals Mission," Modi said, adding that this mission emphasises mining and production of critical minerals. Additionally, a scheme of Rs 1,500 crore has been launched to promote the recycling of minerals, he said.

PM Modi referred to the announcement of a 'rare earth corridor' in this year's Budget, encompassing coastal states such as Odisha, Andhra Pradesh, Tamil Nadu, and Kerala.

"This corridor will serve as an integrated network, forging a robust value chain spanning mining, refining, and manufacturing. Our objective is to establish a national reserve of critical minerals within the country. It would have been ideal had this initiative commenced 30 or 40 years ago; nevertheless, India is now pursuing this objective in a dedicated 'mission mode,' he said.

Markets slip in FY26, fundraising stays resilient: NSE report

Fund mobilisation rises 9% Y-o-Y

MPOST BUREAU

MUMBAI: India's capital markets saw a mixed performance in FY26, with benchmark indices declining even as fundraising activity and investor participation remained strong, according to the NSE Annual Highlights FY26 report.

The Nifty 50 closed at 22,331 on March 30, 2026, down 5.1 percent from a year earlier, while the Sensex fell 7.1 percent to 71,948. Broader markets showed varied trends, with the Nifty Midcap 150 rising 1.6 percent, even as small-cap and total market indices declined. Meanwhile, the rupee weakened sharply, depreciating 10.6 percent against the US dollar during the year.

Despite the subdued equity performance, fundraising activity remained resilient. Total fund mobilisation across equity and debt rose 9 percent year-on-year to Rs 20.3 lakh crore. Equity fundraising alone reached Rs 4.47 lakh crore, marking a 5 percent increase. Debt issuances also grew 10 percent to Rs 15.5 lakh crore, driven by a 30 percent surge in commercial paper issuances.

Primary markets saw steady activity, with 219 IPOs launched in FY26 compared to 242 in the previous year. However, the total

The Nifty closed at 22,331 on March 30, 2026, down 5.1% from a year earlier

amount raised through IPOs increased to Rs 1.78 lakh crore. The number of main-board IPOs rose to 108, while SME listings declined to 111.

Investor participation continued to expand rapidly. The total number of registered investors reached 12.9 crore by March 2026, with 1.6 crore new investors added during the year. Uttar Pradesh led new registrations with a 14 percent share, followed by Maharashtra and Gujarat.

In secondary markets, trading activity moderated across key segments. Cash market turnover declined 7.3 percent, while equity futures and options also saw lower volumes.

However, India maintained a strong global position, with the NSE ranking first in equity derivatives trading by number of contracts, accounting for over 50 percent global share.

Overall, FY26 reflected a year of consolidation for equities, alongside continued growth in capital raising and a broadening investor base.

Investors face Rs 51L cr wealth erosion since start of West Asia war; Sensex tanks over 11%

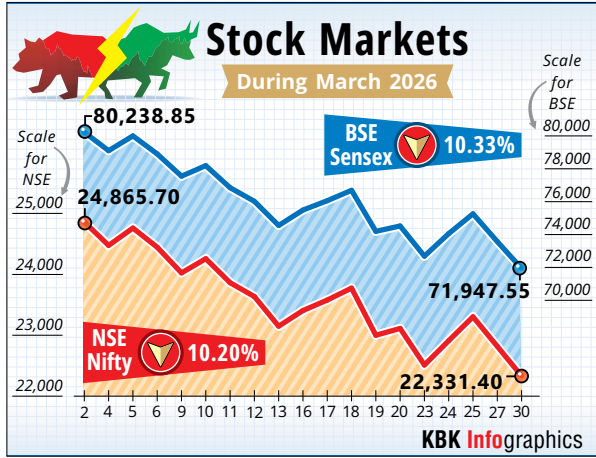
NEW DELHI: Dalal Street investors have lost a whopping Rs 51 lakh crore from their wealth since the West Asia conflict began late last month, with the BSE benchmark Sensex tumbling over 11 per cent during this time, as investors fled riskier assets due to the cascading effect of the war on crude oil prices and markets globally.

Markets also faced the blow of foreign fund exodus from domestic equities.

Since the West Asia conflict started on February 28, the BSE benchmark has crashed 9,339.64 points or 11.48 per cent (10.33 per cent in March).

Tracking the sharp fall in equities, the market capitalisation of BSE-listed companies fell by Rs 51,09,498.82 crore to Rs 4,12,41,172.45 crore (USD 4.36 trillion) this month.

"The current bearish trend is largely externally driven rather than fundamentally broken. Elevated crude oil prices,



geopolitical risks in the Middle East, and sustained FII selling have created a risk-off environment," Ponmudi R, CEO - Enrich Money, said.

From its all-time high of 86,159.02, the BSE benchmark index is down 14,211.47 points or 16.49 per cent. Brent crude, the global oil benchmark, surged 4.15 per cent to

USD 117.46 per barrel. Foreign investors have withdrawn over Rs 1 lakh crore from domestic equities in March, making it the worst monthly outflow, weighed down by escalating tensions in West Asia and a weakening rupee.

Pabitra Mukherjee, Associate Vice President - Technical Research, Bajaj Broking, said,

Reserve Bank extends export credit relief till June 30 amid Mideast crisis

MUMBAI: The Reserve Bank of India on Tuesday extended the enhanced export credit period of up to 450 days for pre-shipment and post-shipment finance for disbursements made till June 30, citing continuing logistical disruptions due to the ongoing West Asia crisis. The central bank had first introduced the measures in November 2025 amid the US tariff wars.

On Tuesday, the Reserve Bank of India (RBI) said it

has been receiving representations from various stakeholders regarding difficulties in adhering to timelines for realisation export proceeds due to geopolitical uncertainties and supply chain disruptions.

In a notification, the regulator said the enhanced export credit period of 450 days, which was earlier available for disbursements made till March 31, 2026, will now be applicable for all disbursements till June 30, 2026.

The RBI also clarified that

the earlier relaxation extending the time period for realisation and repatriation of the full export value of goods, software and services from nine months to 15 months from the date of export will continue to remain in force. "Given the continuing logistical disruptions due to the West Asia crisis, it has been decided to extend the enhanced export credit period of 450 days for all disbursements made till June 30, 2026," the central bank said.

'ICONIC AVIATION LEADER'

IndiGo appoints IATA chief William Walsh as new CEO

MPOST BUREAU

NEW DELHI: The country's largest airline IndiGo on Tuesday announced the appointment of William Walsh, a pilot and current chief of the global airlines' grouping IATA, as its next CEO.

The appointment comes less than three weeks after the sudden exit of Pieter Elbers against the backdrop of massive operational disruptions at the airline in December last year.

An airline industry veteran, Walsh, popularly known as Willie, was formerly CEO of British Airways and IAG (International Airlines Group, a holding company, which owns Aer Lingus, British Airways, Iberia, Level and Vueling).

Announcing the appointment of Walsh as the CEO, which is subject to regulatory approvals, IndiGo, in a release, said his tenure at IATA comes to a close on July 31 and is expected to join no later than August 3.



FILE PIC

The International Air Transport Association (IATA) is the global grouping of airlines, including IndiGo, Air India, Air India Express and SpiceJet. The appointment of Walsh was approved by the board of InterGlobe Aviation on Tuesday.

As IndiGo CEO, Walsh will be responsible for the overall management and strategic direction of the airline with a focus on transformational initiatives to strengthen the operational performance, advance the company's network and commercial strategy while enhanc-

ing customer experience. "He will work closely with the board and the leadership team to rightfully position IndiGo as it scales up to the next phase of its growth," the airline said.

Walsh will also be among the few CEOs who are also pilots. Only a handful of people who were pilots have helmed an Indian airline. He will be the third foreign CEO for IndiGo, which started operations in August 2006.

As the IATA chief, Walsh is known to express his views in a frank and direct manner.

IndiGo Managing Director Rahul Bhatia described Walsh as an "iconic and accomplished aviation leader". Bhatia said Walsh brings a rare combination of global perspective, operational expertise of having built strong customer-focused airlines, deep industry experience and a values-driven leadership, making him exceptionally suited to lead IndiGo at this pivotal cusp of growth.

All 7 ITR forms for AY 2026-2027 notified

NEW DELHI: The Income Tax department has notified all income tax return forms for the assessment year (AY) 2026-27.

While ITR forms 1-4, filed by small and medium taxpayers, were notified on March 30, ITR forms 2, 3, 5, 6 and 7, as well as ITR-U (for filing updated returns), were notified on Tuesday.

With the ITR (income tax return) notification, individuals, businesses and other entities can start filing I-T returns for the income earned in the financial year 2025-26.

The last date for filing ITR for individuals and those who do not have to get their accounts audited is July 31.

ITR Form 1 (Sahaj) and ITR Form 4 (Sugam) are simpler forms that cater to a large number of small and medium taxpayers.

Sahaj can be filed by a resident individual having annual income up to Rs 50 lakh and

who receives income from salary, one house property, other sources and agricultural income up to Rs 5,000 a year.

Sugam can be filed by individuals, Hindu Undivided Families (HUFs) and firms (other than Limited Liability Partnerships (LLPs)) having total annual income up to Rs 50 lakh and income from business and profession.

ITR-2 is filed by individuals and HUFs who do not have income from profits and gains in business or profession, but have income from capital gains. ITR-3 is for individuals and HUFs earning income from a proprietary business or profession.

ITR-5 is filed by firms and limited liability partnership and cooperative societies.

ITR-6 is filed by companies registered under Companies Act.

ITR-7 is filed by trusts and charitable institutions. MPOST

RETIREMENT-CUM-PROMOTION



Newly appointed General Manager Ajay Nandan poses with retiring and promoted employees during a Retirement-cum-Promotion ceremony at the Rail Coach Factory, Kapurthala. A total of 48 employees were handed over retirement benefits, while 39 were given promotion letters during the programme on Tuesday

NTPC Green Energy Limited Group crosses 10 GW installed capacity

NEW DELHI: The NTPC Green Energy Limited (NGEL) Group has crossed the landmark of 10 GW installed capacity, reaching 10,076 MW as of March 31, following the declaration of commercial operation of 78.02 MW under the NTPC REL (a wholly owned subsidiary of NGEL) Khavda-I RE Project and 90 MW under the Khavda-II Project.

The group added an impressive 4,175 MW during FY 2025-26, including 2,065 MW in the January-March quarter alone. With the latest additions, Khavda-I has reached its full capacity of 1,255 MW, while Khavda-II stands at 1,005 MW out of a planned 1,200 MW.

Together, the Khavda Renewable Energy Park now contributes 2,560 MW, all commissioned within the current financial year, reinforcing NGEL's push towards a cleaner and sustainable energy future.

MPOST

India's average monthly mobile data usage per user hits 31 GB in 2025: Nokia report

'Now, 5G contributes nearly 47 per cent of the country's overall mobile broadband traffic'

MPOST BUREAU

NEW DELHI: India's average monthly mobile data consumption per user crossed the 31 GB mark in 2025, up from 27.5 GB in 2024, according to a report by telecom gear maker Nokia.

The 13th edition of Nokia's annual Mobile Broadband Index (MBIT) said pan-India monthly 5G data traffic surged 70 per cent year-on-year to reach 12.9 exabytes (EB) in 2025.

With this, 5G now contributes nearly 47 per cent of the country's overall mobile broadband traffic.

"Average monthly mobile data consumption per user increased to over 31 GB in 2025, representing an 18 per cent compound annual growth rate over the past five years. This growth reflects the rapid expansion of enhanced Mobile Broadband (eMBB) and growing demand for data-intensive use cases, such as AI applications, 4K video streaming and cloud gaming," the report noted.

Overall data traffic in India



REPRESENTATIVE PIC

crossed 27 EB per month in 2025, registering a compound annual growth rate (CAGR) of 21.7 per cent over the past five years.

According to the report, India now boasts the world's second-largest 5G subscriber base, the second-highest level of 5G data consumption, and the second-largest 5G Fixed Wireless Access (FWA) user base globally. FWA emerged as a key catalyst for data traffic growth, with its

share of overall 5G data crossing 25 per cent. The report noted a two-fold year-on-year growth in 5G FWA subscribers.

"India's mobile broadband landscape is entering a new phase of evolution, driven by rapid 5G adoption and the growing influence of AI-led applications.

"As networks transform to support new usage patterns and intelligent services, Nokia remains committed to partner-

KEY POINTS

- » The 13th edition of Nokia's annual Mobile Broadband Index (MBIT) said pan-India monthly 5G data traffic surged 70 per cent year-on-year to reach 12.9 exabytes (EB) in 2025
- » Overall data traffic in India crossed 27 EB per month in 2025, registering a compound annual growth rate (CAGR) of 21.7 per cent over the past five years
- » India now boasts the world's second-largest 5G subscriber base, the second-highest level of 5G data consumption, and the second-largest 5G Fixed Wireless Access (FWA) user base globally
- » FWA emerged as a key catalyst for data traffic growth, with its share of overall 5G data crossing 25 per cent

ing with telcos to build scalable, high-performance and future-ready connectivity infrastructure," Vibha Mehra, Country Manager - Designate for India, Nokia, said.

The report stated that metro circles continue to lead 5G adoption, with the 5G technology now accounting for 58 per cent of total mobile data traffic in these markets.

On the device ecosystem front, the number of active 4G

devices reached 892 million in 2025, of which over 383 million are already 5G-capable.

The transition is being fuelled by a massive 10-fold year-on-year growth in budget 5G phone shipments (priced under USD 100). Over 90 per cent of all smartphones shipped during the year supported 5G.

Looking ahead, the Nokia MBIT Index projects that India's 5G subscriber base could exceed 1 billion by 2031.

US: Mesabi Metalics secures \$520 million from Breakwall Capital

NEW DELHI: Mesabi Metalics Company LLC, backed by Essar Group, has secured a USD 520 million senior secured credit facility from funds managed by Breakwall Capital LP, as it advances towards starting operations at its Minnesota iron ore project later this year.

Located on more than 16,000 acres in northern Minnesota, Mesabi Metalics is completing a \$2.5 billion world-scale merchant Direct Reduction (DR) grade iron ore mine and pellet plant that will onshore a strategically important segment of the US steel supply chain.

The financing, provided by Breakwall-managed Valor Mining Credit Partners II in partnership with Vitol, supports the development of a USD 2.5 billion direct reduction (DR)-grade iron ore mine and pellet plant to strengthen the US steel supply chain, the company said in a statement.

Located on more than 16,000 acres in northern Minnesota, the project is among the largest private industrial invest-

ments in the state, with over USD 2 billion of equity already invested by Essar.

The company said the project, which has also received backing from the Export-Import Bank of the United States, is expected to reduce reliance on imported raw materials and support domestic steel production across sectors, including automotive, infrastructure and defence.

The construction is ongoing with more than 750 workers onsite, and the project is targeting commercial operations later in 2026.

Essar Group has already invested over \$2 billion of equity into the project.

"The partnership with Breakwall is an important milestone for Mesabi Metalics," said Joe Broking, President and CEO of Mesabi Metalics.

"We are bringing to market a brand-new American source of the highest quality DR-grade iron ore that will help US steelmakers reduce reliance on imported raw materials and international supply chains," Broking said.

MPOST

Cooper’s super act

Connolly shines on debut to power PBKS to three-wicket win over GT

MULLANPUR: Young south-paw Cooper Connolly marked his IPL debut with a decisive 44-ball 72 after Yuzvendra Chahal's artistry with the ball to power Punjab Kings to a three-wicket victory over Gujarat Titans here on Tuesday.

After PBKS opted to field first, leg-spinner Chahal (2/28 in 4 overs) brought his years of experience to the fore to stymie GT in the middle overs and limit them to 162/6.

Seamer Vijaykumar Vyshak grabbed 3/34 for PBKS.

After almost losing their way with the bat due to Prasidh Krishna's (3/29 in 4 overs) excellent bowling, PBKS completed the chase of 163 with five balls to spare. Connolly and Prabhsimran Singh (37 off 24 balls) laid the foundation for the win with a 76-run partnership for the second wicket.

Earlier, skipper Shubman Gill (39 off 27 balls) and Jos Buttler (38 off 33 balls) were the chief contributors for GT in an insipid batting display.

PBKS' start was not good as Kagiso Rabada cramped Priyansh Arya for room with his pace and line to dismiss the opener after debutant fast bowler Ashok Sharma went back a few steps to pull off a good catch at midwicket.

Connolly and Prabhsimran



Punjab Kings' Cooper Connolly celebrates his fifty with Marco Jansen

PTI

then meant business as they went about their task in a professional manner to keep their team ahead, the two hitting a flurry of fours and sixes to flatten the GT bowlers.

Rashid Khan gave GT hope with the wicket of Prabhsimran, the batter failing to clear Prasadh Krishna at long-on.

Shreyas Iyer pulled Ashok Kumar's short balls over deep square-leg for two sixes but, shortly after taking a solid

hit off his partner Connolly's shot, the PBKS captain flicked a Prasadh Krishna half-volley to Washington Sundar at deep mid-wicket. Sundar removed Nehal Wadhwa, and Krishna dismissed Shashank Singh and Marcus Stoinis in quick succession to bring GT back into contention. But Connolly was there to see PBKS home, hitting five sixes and as many fours during his knock.

Earlier, sent into bat, Gill dealt in boundaries as the side raced to 35 in three overs.

Gill looked in sublime touch as he picked the gaps at will to score at a good clip, forcing PBKS skipper Shreyas Iyer to effect a bowling change and introduce the tall Marco Jansen (1/20 in 4 overs) into the attack.

The move paid dividends as pacer Jansen got Sai Sudharsan (13) to slice one towards mid-off where Shreyas completed a simple catch.

AGENCIES

Undav snatches late winner for Germany

STUTTGART: Germany forward Deniz Undav came off the bench to score an 88th-minute goal that secured a 2-1 victory over Ghana in a friendly on Monday, boosting his chances of making the World Cup squad.

The VfB Stuttgart striker, who is second on the Bundesliga scorers' list with 18 goals, made the most of a second-half appearance in front of a home crowd, bagging the winner with a flick over the Ghana keeper. The winning goal came after Germany coach Julian Nagelsmann had raised eyebrows on Friday when Undav was left on the bench as they beat Switzerland 4-3.

"A perfect evening. It was amazing to hear this support from the fans," Undav said. "I came in and scored the goal but what is more important is that we won the game." "I accept my role and maybe if I score more goals like this my role may change, who knows."

Dream debut for Williams as India avenge Asia Cup loss to Hong Kong

KOCHI: Australian-born Ryan Williams made a dream India debut as his fourth-minute strike set up the home side's 2-1 win over Hong Kong in an inconsequential Asian Cup qualifying round match here on Tuesday.

Akash Mishra scored the other goal for India in the 50th minute, also his first international strike, to help the Khalid Jamil-coached side notch their first victory of the third round of the qualifiers.

Already out of contention for the continental showpiece, India ended their campaign with five points -- from one win and two draws -- and at the bottom of Group C.

Evertton Camargo pulled one back for Hong Kong in the 65th minute.

India had lost to Hong Kong 0-1 in the first leg on June 10 last year in Kowloon. Singapore, who beat Bangladesh 1-0 at home earlier in the day, qualified for the 2027 Asian Cup as Group C toppers with 14 points from six matches. Williams slotted home with a first time



Ryan Williams scored the opening goal in their 2-1 win

AIFF

Already out of contention, India ended their campaign with five points

right footer into the back of the net after a brilliant low delivery into the middle by Manvir Singh to give the big Kochi crowd a wonderful moment to cheer in just the fourth minute.

Williams was included in the squad after FIFA cleared

his change of association, paving the way for the 31-year-old winger to represent India at the senior international level.

It was also his international debut as he has not played for Australia in an official senior match. It was the fastest goal scored by a debutant for India, surpassing the previous record of sixth-minute strikes by K Appalaraju against Ceylon (Sri Lanka) in a pre-Olympics match in Colombo in 1963 and Mehtab Hossain against Nepal in the 2005 SAFF Cup in Karachi.

AGENCIES

Pressure on Pant as LSG face Capitals

LUCKNOW: Lucknow Super Giants captain Rishabh Pant will have little room for error in a critical year as his side begins its IPL 2026 campaign against a well-rounded Delhi Capitals here on Wednesday.

Pant could not deliver as a leader and frontline batter in his first year at LSG. Injuries to key players, especially fast bowlers, made his job a lot tougher.

This season, he has a fully fit squad at his disposal that has been bolstered by the addition of old warhorse Mohammed Shami and Anrich Nortje.

Injury prone pace sensation Mayank Yadav has worked hard on his fitness over the past 12 months and LSG would be hoping that he repays the strong faith that franchise had reposed in him. Pacer Mohsin Khan too is making a comeback from injury while Prince Yadav has also impressed with his medium pace in the nets thus far. Mystery spinner Digvesh Singh Rathni made a name for himself in his debut season and would be looking to build on the massive gains that he made 12 months ago.

Compared to the bowling department, the batting has a more settled look with Mitchell Marsh and Aiden Markram forming one of the most lethal opening pairings in the IPL.

Pant, who could not make an impact at No. 4 for majority of last season before slamming a hundred at No. 3, is set to bat in the top-order with Nicholas Pooran to follow at No. 4. LSG take on a side that should have made the play-offs last year after a promising start.

AGENCIES

'High hopes from Green'

SYDNEY: Cameron Green is dealing with huge expectations both in the IPL and in the Australian cricket set-up but the all-rounder has what it takes to balance it out for a career that "will trend upwards", his national head coach Andrew McDonald has said.

Kolkata Knight Riders' skipper Ajinkya Rahane's remark on a currently injured Green not bowling in the IPL match against Mumbai Indians had created a mild controversy on his fitness status.

Later, Cricket Australia clarified that the KKR management is "fully aware" of the 26-year-old's back niggle, which mandates him to be away from bowling for 10-12 days. "There's huge expectation within the IPL, and there's huge expectation with any all-rounder that shapes an Australian team. It's not unfair, but there is an expectation around all-rounders that they contribute in a certain way," McDonald said. Green was bought by KKR for an eye-watering Rs 25.20 crore, making him the most expensive overseas buy ever in the IPL. "It's almost like they want them to average 45 with the bat and average less than 30 with the ball."

AGENCIES

PROCLAMATION REQUIRING THE APPEARANCE OF ACCUSED PERSON

See Section 82 Cr.P.C.

Whereas complaint has been made before me that the accused person Namely **Murshed @ Ghonchu S/o** Sh. Sadre Alam R/o H. No. N-38 B/109 CD Park Jhuggi Jajangirpuri New Delhi has committed (or is suspected to have committed) the offence in case **FIR No. 000601/2023 U/s 380/454/411/34 IPC PS: Tilak Nagar, Delhi** and it has been returned to a warrant of arrest thereupon issued that the said accused **Murshed @ Ghonchu**, cannot be found and whereas it has been shown to my satisfaction that the said accused **Murshed @ Ghonchu**, has absconded (or is concealing himself to avoid the service of the said warrant).

Proclamation is hereby made that the said **Murshed @ Ghonchu**, accused of **FIR No. 000601/2023 U/s 380/454/411/34 IPC PS: Tilak Nagar, Delhi** is required to appear before this Court to answer the said complaint on or before **20.05.2026**.

By Order
Sh. Vikas Madaan
JMFC-07 Room No. 289
Tis Hazari Courts, Delhi

DP/4141/WD/2026
(Court Matter)

M.P. STATE AGRICULTURAL MARKETING BOARD

26- ARERA HILLS, JAIL ROAD, BHOPAL
Board/Const/PC/DVI-2/2025-26/2484 Date : 28.03.2026

NOTICE INVITING TENDER

Online Lump-Sum Rate E-Tenders are invited from the eligible bidders for Selection of an EPC Contractor for turnkey implementation of an AI-based voice-enabled communication and broadcasting system with audio-visual advisory devices for farmers across APMCs of Madhya Pradesh for 24 months. (Tender Number : 2026_MPSAM_494752) (PAC amount Rs. 2533.41 Lakh). The following Tender to be received online up to **5:30 PM on Dated 24.04.2026**. Technical bid documents with EMD & Financial Offer to be received online only as per Detailed NIT. The tender documents can be obtained online on the <http://mptenders.gov.in> as per the Notice Published on the above Portal and detailed information can also be seen on website www.mpmadiboard.gov.in

Note :- Any corrigendum in this NIT, if required, shall be displayed only on above portal regarding any matter included in this NIT or otherwise. Other details of project and locations & key dates can also be seen on our website www.mpmadiboard.gov.in

M.P. Madhyam/125124/2026 EXECUTIVE ENGINEER (Project Cell)

KIND ATTENTION RAIL PASSENGERS! ➡

SUMMER SPECIAL TRAINS - 2026

In order to clear extra rush of passengers during the upcoming Summer season, Railways have decided to run the following Summer Special Trains as per details given below:-

04209/04210 Varanasi - Delhi Jn. - Varanasi Reserved Special Express Train (Tri-Weekly)						76
Train No. 04209			Train No. 04210			Trips
ARR.	DEP.	STATIONS	ARR.	DEP.		
---	22:15	Varanasi	09:50	---		
13:30	---	Delhi Jn.	---	19:25		

DAYS OF RUN: 04209 Ex. Varanasi on every Monday, Wednesday & Friday from 15.04.2026 to 20.05.2026 & 27.05.2026 to 15.07.2026 and 04210 Ex. Delhi Jn. on every Tuesday, Thursday & Saturday from 16.04.2026 to 21.05.2026 & 28.05.2026 to 16.07.2026.

STOPPAGES: Maa Belha Devi Dham, Rae Bareilly, Lucknow, Hardoi, Rampur, Moradabad, Hapur & Ghaziabad Stations.

ACCOMMODATION: AC 2 Tier, AC 3 Tier, Sleeper & General.

04203/04204 Lucknow - New Delhi - Lucknow Reserved Special Express Train (Weekly)						26
Train No. 04203			Train No. 04204			Trips
ARR.	DEP.	STATIONS	ARR.	DEP.		
---	08:05	Lucknow	06:35	---		
18:30	---	New Delhi	---	20:20		

DAYS OF RUN: 04203 Ex. Lucknow and 04204 Ex. New Delhi on every Monday from 20.04.2026 to 13.07.2026.

STOPPAGES: Balamau Jn., Shahjahanpur, Bareilly, Moradabad, Amroha, Hapur & Ghaziabad Stations.

ACCOMMODATION: 1st AC, AC 2 Tier, AC 3 Tier, Sleeper & General.

04213/04214 Ayodhya Cantt - Anand Vihar (T) - Ayodhya Cantt Reserved Special Express Train (Bi-Weekly)						48
Train No. 04213			Train No. 04214			Trips
ARR.	DEP.	STATIONS	ARR.	DEP.		
---	18:20	Ayodhya Cantt	22:00	---		
00:48	00:50	Bareilly Jn.	13:03	13:05		
06:00	---	Anand Vihar (T)	---	09:00		

DAYS OF RUN: 04213 Ex. Ayodhya Cantt on every Sunday & Thursday from 16.04.2026 to 17.05.2026 & 28.05.2026 to 12.07.2026 and 04214 Ex. Anand Vihar (T) on every Monday & Friday from 17.04.2026 to 18.05.2026 & 29.05.2026 to 13.07.2026.

STOPPAGES: Barabanki, Lucknow, Bareilly, Moradabad, Hapur & Ghaziabad Stations.

ACCOMMODATION: AC 2 Tier, AC 3 Tier, Sleeper & General.

04010/04009 Delhi Jn. - Sitamarhi - Delhi Jn. Reserved Special Express Train (Weekly)						26
Train No. 04010			Train No. 04009			Trips
ARR.	DEP.	STATIONS	ARR.	DEP.		
---	23:05	Delhi Jn.	23:10	---		
23:30	---	Sitamarhi	---	01:00		

DAYS OF RUN: 04010 Ex. Delhi Jn. on every Thursday from 16.04.2026 to 09.07.2026 and 04009 Ex. Sitamarhi on every Friday from 17.04.2026 to 10.07.2026.

STOPPAGES: Ghaziabad, Hapur, Moradabad, Bareilly, Shahjahanpur, Sitapur, Gonda Jn., Gorakhpur, Bagaha, Narkatiaganj Jn., Sikta, Raxaul Jn. & Baigania Stations.

ACCOMMODATION: 1st AC, AC 2 Tier, AC 3 Tier, AC 3 Tier Economy, Sleeper & General.

04052/04051 New Delhi - Howrah Jn. - New Delhi Reserved Special Express Train (Weekly)						24
Train No. 04052			Train No. 04051			Trips
ARR.	DEP.	STATIONS	ARR.	DEP.		
---	18:15	New Delhi	08:20	---		
23:40	---	Howrah Jn.	---	01:40		

DAYS OF RUN: 04052 Ex. New Delhi on every Friday from 17.04.2026 to 15.05.2026 & 29.05.2026 to 10.07.2026 and 04051 Ex. Howrah Jn. on every Sunday from 19.04.2026 to 17.05.2026 & 31.05.2026 to 12.07.2026.

STOPPAGES: Ghaziabad, Aligarh Jn., Tundla Jn., Govindpur, Prayagraj Jn., Mirzapur, Pt. Deen Dayal Upadhyaya Jn., Buxar, Ara, Patna Jn., Bakhtiyarpur Jn., Kiul Jn., Jhajha, Jasidih Jn., Madhupur Jn., Chittaranjan, Asansol Jn., Durgapur, Bardhaman & Bandel Stations.

ACCOMMODATION: AC 3 Tier, Sleeper & General.

For any kind of information, passengers are requested to contact RailMadad Helpline No. 139 or visit Indian Railways website <https://enquiry.indianrail.gov.in> or NTES App.

08743/08744 Durg - Haridwar Jn. - Durg Special Express Train (Weekly)						22
Train No. 08743			Train No. 08744			Trips
ARR.	DEP.	STATIONS	ARR.	DEP.		
---	11:00	Durg	03:00	---		
17:30	---	Haridwar Jn.	---	18:55		

DAYS OF RUN: 08743 Ex. Durg on every Sunday from 19.04.2026 to 28.06.2026 and 08744 Ex. Haridwar Jn. on every Monday from 20.04.2026 to 29.06.2026.

STOPPAGES: Raipur Jn., Bhatapara, Uslapur, Pendra Road, Anuppur Jn., Shahdol, Umaria, Katni Murwara, Damoh, Saugor, Virangana Lakshmbai Jhansi Jn., Gwalior Jn., Dholpur, Agra Cantt, Mathura Jn., Kosi Kalan, Hazrat Nizamuddin, Meerut City & Roorkee Stations.

ACCOMMODATION: AC 3 Tier, Sleeper & General.

Extension of Periodicity of Train No. 04652/04651 Amritsar - Jaynagar - Amritsar Humsafar Special Express					
Train No.	From	To	Earlier Notified up to	Proposed Period of Extension	Trips
04652	Amritsar	Jaynagar	29.03.26	01.04.26 to 15.07.26	46
04651	Jaynagar	Amritsar	31.03.26	03.04.26 to 17.07.26	46

Extension of Periodicity of Train No. 05736/05735 Katihar - Amritsar - Katihar Summer Special						
Train No.	From	To	Day of Run	Earlier Notified up to	Proposed Period of Extension	Trips
05736	Katihar	Amritsar	Wed	25.03.26	01.04.26 to 27.05.26	09
05735	Amritsar	Katihar	Fri	27.03.26	03.04.26 to 29.05.26	09

Revised Timings of Train No. 05736/05735					
Katihar - Amritsar - Katihar Special at following stations					
Train No. 05736		STATIONS	Train No. 05735		
ARR.	DEP.		ARR.	DEP.	
----	21:00	Katihar	23:45	----	
22:07	22:09	Shahjahanpur	00:19	00:21	
23:05	23:10	Bareilly	23:07	23:09	
00:25	00:33	Moradabad	21:45	21:50	
02:08	02:10	Laksar Jn.	20:08	20:10	
02:30	02:32	Roorkee	19:43	19:45	
04:00	04:05	Saharanpur Jn.	19:00	19:08	
09:45	----	Amritsar	----	13:25	

Note: Rest all information will hold good.

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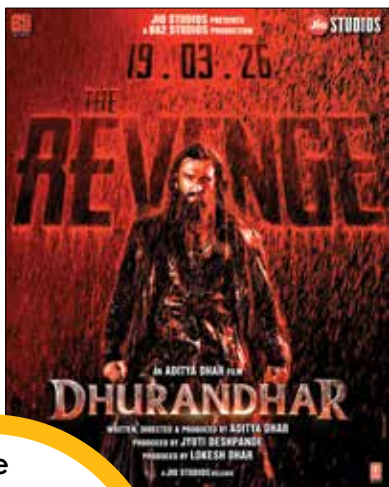
Arjun celebrates responses to ‘Dhurandhar 2’

‘I am over the moon,’ says the Bollywood actor

Bollywood actor Arjun Rampal expressed his gratitude to all his supporters following the success of ‘Dhurandhar: The Revenge’.

The actor went down memory lane and shared a series of throwback pictures on his ‘Instagram’ handle, also adding the behind-the-scenes pictures from the sets of ‘Dhurandhar’.

Featuring Ranveer Singh in the lead, ‘Dhurandhar’ released in 2025, followed by the release of the latest instalment on March 19, both were directed by Aditya Dhar. The first film



The actor went down memory lane and shared a series of throwback pictures on his ‘Instagram’ handle

crossed Rs 1000 crore globally and the second release earned over Rs 1300 crore at the global box office.

“From playing cowboys as kids, to landing my first film #moksha to #Dhurandhar, I am blessed to have been with everyone who was part of the journey. Thank you, my dearest fan family, for sticking with me on the ride, thank you to this incredible #Dhurandhar family @adityadharfilms @vik_now @ojas_gautam for being my pillars and of course, mera Babbar sher @ranveersingh #lokeshdhar jyotideshpande shweta @castingchhabra @actormaddy @therakeshbedi @duttanjan @preetisheel smriti this list will keep growing,” Rampal wrote in the post.

He added, “I am over the moon. Patience, perseverance and passion stick with them and dreams come true. @dhurandhartherevenge and of course the mesmerising @shashwatology, your music

is phenomenal. The action team, the fabulous @dokkaebi530 and @msjoeykim thank you for everything.”

The latest film, where Rampal essays the role of Major Iqbal, also stars R Madhavan, Arjun Rampal, Sanjay Dutt, Sara Arjun and Rakesh Bedi, who are reprising their roles. Set in Lyari town of Karachi, an area known for its history of gang wars and violent turf battles, ‘Dhurandhar’ revolved around covert intelligence operations against the backdrop of geopolitical and terror events like the Kandahar plane hijack, the 2001 Parliament Attack and the 26/11 Mumbai attacks.

The sequel charts the rise of Singh’s character Hamza Ali Mazari in the Karachi underworld while also delving into his origins as Jaskirat Singh Rangji, tracing the journey of the young man who eventually transforms into the covert operative. PII

‘I’m disappearing for a while’

Zendaya is set to feature alongside Robert Pattinson in ‘The Drama’

Hollywood star Zendaya said she will be ‘disappearing’ for a while following a lineup of her back-to-back films.

Zendaya is set to feature alongside Robert Pattinson in ‘The Drama’, followed by the final season of the drama series ‘Euphoria’, ‘Spider-Man: Brand New Day’, ‘Dune: Part Three’, and ‘The Odyssey’. According to reports, she will also feature in ‘Avengers: Doomsday’.

The actress said she hopes the audience doesn’t get ‘sick’ of her and extended gratitude to her fans.

The actress hopes the audience doesn’t get ‘sick’ of her and extends gratitude to her fans

“I just hope people don’t get sick of me and I really appreciate everyone who supports any of the movies and supports my career in any kind of way. I’m deeply appreciative,” she told ‘Fandango’ in an interview.

She added, “I just hope you guys don’t get sick of me this year because I’ll tell you what, I’m disappearing for a little bit. I’m going to have to go into hiding for just a little bit.”

Her next film, ‘The Drama’, is set to release on April 3 and is directed by Kristoffer Borgli. It revolves around an engaged couple who get put to the test when an unexpected revelation sends their wedding week off the rails. PII



ARIRANG

BTS lands seventh on ‘Billboard 200 No. 1’

BTS has claimed their seventh No. 1 album on the ‘Billboard 200’ with ‘Arirang’, their first full group project in nearly four years since completing mandatory military service. The album opened with 641,000 equivalent album units earned in its first tracking week, the largest opening week for an album by a group since Billboard began measuring by equivalent album units in December 2014. The debut cements what many had already suspected since the album’s release on March 20: that the group’s return from a year-long hiatus, one defined by solo careers and mandatory service, had done nothing to diminish their grip on the global music market.

The numbers behind the debut are staggering across every metric. Of Arirang’s 641,000 equivalent album units, pure album sales comprise 532,000, the group’s biggest sales week ever, while streaming equivalent album units comprise 95,000, equaling 99.10 million on-demand official streams, also BTS’ biggest streaming week ever for an album.

Physical sales drove much of the performance chart, according to a report by ‘Billboard’. Arirang’s first-week sales were largely powered by physical copies, with vinyl sales accounting for 208,000, BTS’ best sales week on vinyl and the largest by a group in the modern era since ‘Luminate’ began electronically tracking sales

in 1991. It is also the sixth-largest vinyl sales week for an album in the modern era, with Taylor Swift holding the top five spots. The album was made available in 17 vinyl variants and nine CD editions, all featuring the same track list, along with collectable items including photocards, stickers, and posters.

The fifth studio album also topped the ‘UK Official Albums Chart’, sweeping both the UK and US album charts, widely regarded as the world’s two most important music charts

Streaming metrics reinforce the scale of the debut. Across its first seven days, ‘Arirang’ generated over 545 million streams on ‘Spotify’, delivering the biggest debut week of 2026 and the eighth largest in the platform’s history. Opening day numbers were equally strong, with over 110 million streams logged on March 20, marking the biggest single-day total for a K-pop album.

The fifth studio album also topped the ‘UK Official Albums Chart’, sweeping both the UK and US album charts, widely regarded as the world’s two most important music charts. AGENCIES



Zack Snyder praises Huma Qureshi

Filmmaker Zack Snyder recalled working with Bollywood actor Huma Qureshi and said she brings ‘pure brilliance on screen’. Snyder directed the 2021 film, in which the actress essayed the role of Geeta. It was released on ‘Netflix’. Also starring Ella Purnell and Dave Bautista, the film revolved around a group of mercenaries who take the ultimate gamble and venture into the quarantine zone in hopes of pulling off an impossible heist, following a zombie outbreak.

Snyder directed the 2021 film, in which the actress essayed the role of Geeta

Snyder shared a poster of the film, featuring Qureshi on his ‘Instagram’ handle on Tuesday. “@iamhumaq, one of the most amazing actors I’ve had the pleasure of working with on ‘Army of the Dead’: Talent, presence and pure brilliance on screen,” he wrote in the caption.



The ‘Gangs of Wasseypur’ star reshared the post and left a comment, which read, “You the best, boss man.” The film also served as her Hollywood debut.

She will next feature in ‘Toxic: A Fairy Tale for Grown-Ups’, which is led by Yash. The film is directed by Geetu Mohandas and is set to release on June 4. It features the actor in the role of Elizabeth. The film also stars Kiara Advani, Nayanthara and Tara Sutaria in pivotal roles. PII

‘EUPHORIA’ SEASON 3 TRAILER

Zendaya, Jacob Elordi & Sydney Sweeney’s show gets a ‘Tarantino’

After an exciting end to the last season, fans have been waiting for ‘Euphoria’ Season 3 to see where the story will take the unique characters of the show. The makers have shared a glimpse of the same in the recently released trailer of the show and it looks sinister, but also a bit snazzy.

In the last season, all the main characters of the show finished high school and the trailer of Season 3 reveals a five-year time lapse. It begins with Rue (Zendaya), who has been battling addiction throughout the show, seen driving in the desert in Mexico. She is then seen in a room being questioned by DEA (Drug Enforcement Administration) agents about a drug deal. In the next scene, we see her dealing with a Mexican drug dealer. The following glimpses show Cassie (Sydney Sweeney) getting married to Nate (Jacob Elordi), while Lexi (Maude Apatow) heads to Hollywood.

The biggest surprise is Cassie



In the last season, all the main characters of the show finished high school and the trailer of S3 reveals a five-year time lapse

the audience aware of the dangers that are always lurking behind them.

The new trailer shows how the makers have taken the show into a more dangerous, criminal and vengeful space, far removed from its beginnings as a story about school students. A fan in the comments section called it ‘Euphoria: Tarantino Edition’.

Apart from the old cast, famous faces including Sharon Stone, Rosalía, Danielle Deadwyler, Marshawn Lynch and others will also appear on the show. AGENCIES

TIGER SHROFF ON STRUGGLING WITH AEROPHOBIA

‘IT IS FRUSTRATING’

The ‘Baaghi’ star said that he starts feeling anxious a couple of days before every flight

Unlike actor Jackie Shroff, who rose to fame and became a star playing a wide range of characters across various languages, his son, Tiger Shroff, has mostly grabbed attention for his action roles. Starting from his debut movie, director Sabbir Khan’s ‘Heropanti’ (2014), Tiger has primarily played power-packed characters in films such as ‘War’, ‘Heropanti 2’, ‘Ganapath’, ‘Bade Miyan Chote Miyan’, ‘Singham Again’ and the four ‘Baaghi’ movies. As a result, he is known for maintaining a ripped, gym-honed physique almost all the time.

Although he is often appreciated by fans for his



ability to ace stunts effortlessly, including even the riskiest ones, on-screen, Tiger has aerophobia as the daring, adventurous actor actually has an extreme fear of flying in an aeroplane.

In a recent interview, Tiger opened up about this and shared that he is contemplating starting therapy to address the condition.

“I’m actually planning to go to a therapist because I have aerophobia. A couple of years ago, I was on a very turbulent flight and I don’t have control over a turbulent flight, right? What do I do? Ever since then, every time I have to board a flight, I have anxiety a couple of days prior. For some reason, I’m still not able to get over that,” he shared during a conversation with ‘YouTuber’ Lilly Singh. Tiger continued,

“The statistics say that flying is the safest means of transport. I have spoken to many pilots who all said that turbulence is nothing but just like bumpy roads. That’s the analogy they keep giving me. But who’s going to tell my mind that? When it happens, it’s a different story altogether.” AGENCIES

‘I wish I had control over that. I like controlling every part of my body,’ he says

